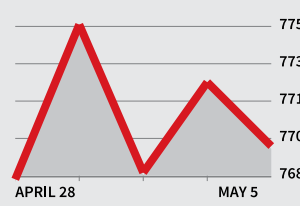


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77017.79 (-251.61)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24032.80	-86.50
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.91	-0.06
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.28	+0.20
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	147045.00	-462
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	240465.00	+345



WAR EFFECT.

Even if the Gulf war ends soon, it will take 3-4 months for logistics and energy capacities to stabilise, says CII chief Rajiv Memani **p3**

POLLSCAPE.

Cong has indicated willingness to support TVK, which is looking for numbers to form the govt in TN **p7**

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QUICKLY.

ANNUAL MAINTENANCE
RIL plans to shut one refinery unit in Gujarat



Mumbai: Reliance Industries will be shutting down one of its refinery units in Gujarat, with a capacity to refine 3.3 lakh barrels of crude a day, as part of its annual maintenance exercise, sources said, though no definite date has been specified. The shutdown is expected some time in June, though sources aware of the matter said that it could happen later too. **p12**

TOP DECK IN BIOCON
Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw picks niece as heir apparent

Bengaluru: In an industry where woman-led boardrooms remain rare, Biocon is scripting a rare double, founded by a woman and set to be led by one again, as Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw named her niece Claire Mazumdar as her heir apparent. Signalling a phased handover rather than an immediate exit, Shaw said in a post on X that Claire would “transition into my role at the right time,” adding, she is “not planning to hang up my boots just yet.” **p12**

AI trims international flights in May as rising ATF costs bite

TURBULENCE. Cuts N. America, Europe, S-E Asia services as OMCs raise fuel price by 5%

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Tata Group-promoted Air India has reduced flight frequencies across several key international routes for May, with reductions of 5 per cent on some routes and up to 25 per cent on others, industry sources told *businessline*.

The move comes as oil marketing companies (OMCs) on May 1 decided to increase the price of jet fuel sold for international flights by 5 per cent, adding further cost pressure on airlines already grappling with elevated operational expenses.

Air India did not respond to queries from *businessline*.

CURTAILED OPS

North America operations for May have been curtailed by about 20 per cent, with about 40 out of 200 flights it had previously scheduled to operate throughout the month cancelled.

On European routes, the airline has reduced its weekly frequency on Paris, Copenhagen and Zurich routes, cancelling close to 20 flights through the month from over 450 flights it had



HEADWINDS. The recalibration reflects ongoing network optimisation in response to demand moderation, rising fuel costs and evolving operational conditions across global markets

planned to operate.

Australia, another key long-haul market for Air India, saw two out of seven weekly flights cancelled on both the Melbourne and Sydney routes.

South-East Asia frequencies have been reduced by 10 per cent for the month.

As per sources, the recalibration reflects ongoing network optimisation in response to demand moderation, rising fuel costs and evolving operational conditions across global markets.

KEY FACTORS

Industry observers said the combination of higher international jet fuel prices, regulatory cost adjustments and geopolitical disruptions had intensified pressure on long-haul operations, prompting

airlines to reassess capacity deployment across key international routes.

In a recent communication to employees, Air India CEO and Managing Director Campbell Wilson acknowledged the impact of the prevailing geopolitical situation, particularly the developments in West Asia, which have affected jet fuel prices, currency exchange rates and airspace availability.

Wilson said that many international flights had become unprofitable due to higher jet fuel costs and longer flying routes caused by airspace closures.

DOMESTIC ROUTES

He said that while domestic operations had also been affected, the impact remains lower due to government in-

tervention limiting domestic fuel price increases.

According to Wilson, the airline had already reduced select flights for April and May in response to cost escalation pressures, with further schedule adjustments possible for June and July amid continued challenges in the operating environment.

However, Air India has not yet curtailed operations for June and July.

INDIGO'S STANCE

Industry sources pointed out that IndiGo is maintaining a wait-and-watch stance and has so far kept its international capacity intact in May compared to April levels.

Nonetheless, on a year-on-year basis, the airline has reduced operations by around 10 per cent, mostly to the Gulf region due to the ongoing conflict.

IndiGo, too, did not respond to questions in this regard.

Globally, foreign carriers have made similar capacity cuts. Lufthansa recently announced cancelling 20,000 flights between May and October. Qantas has reduced its flights to India at least until October.

Mamata refuses to resign, says TMC did not lose polls

Poornima Joshi
Mithun Dasgupta
New Delhi/Kolkata



A day after her party suffered a major defeat in the West Bengal Assembly elections, Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee said she would not resign as Chief Minister. Banerjee claimed that her party “did not lose” the elections. Rather, the entire electoral process was “rigged” in the BJP’s favour.

“We have not been defeated. I have not been defeated. I will not resign. There is no question of my going to the Raj Bhavan,” she said at a press conference. “In this election, the BJP and the Election Commission played a dirty game. They forcefully grabbed votes.”

She claimed that over 100 seats were “looted” from her party.

By refusing to resign, she has created an unprecedented situation. But it has no bearing on the Constitutional scheme, which has an in-built system of ensuring continuity in government.

Detailed report p7

₹2.55 lakh crore credit support plan for MSMEs, airlines gets Cabinet nod

Our Bureau
New Delhi

To mitigate the West Asia crisis, the Union Cabinet on Tuesday approved the 5th edition of the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS) to support credit flow of ₹2.55 lakh crore with up to 100 per cent government guarantee for MSMEs, non-MSMEs and airlines. It will have ₹5,000 crore separately for airlines.

“It (ECLGS 5.0) reflects our commitment to supporting India’s businesses, especially the MSME sector in these challenging global times. By enabling additional credit flow with strong guarantee coverage, this initiative will help a wide range of sectors. Our focus remains on empowering enterprises, sustaining growth momentum and safeguarding livelihoods,” Prime Minister Narendra Modi said in a social media post.

According to a government statement, the scheme aims to provide credit guarantee coverage of 100 per cent for MSMEs and 90 per cent for non-MSMEs as well as the airlines sector.

An amount of ₹18,100 crore has been provided to meet the obligation on ac-



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw briefing the media on the Cabinet decisions **ANI**

count of default. For MSMEs, support will be up to 20 per cent of peak working capital utilised during Q4 FY26 with a maximum of ₹100 crore.

For airlines, the support will be 100 per cent of peak working capital utilised with a cap of ₹1,500 crore. The tenor of such loan would be 5 years for MSMEs and non-MSMEs, and 7 years for airlines. Loans sanctioned till March 31, 2027, will be eligible for the scheme.

A senior government official said that the rate of interest on MSME and non-MSME loan is capped at 9 per cent for banks and 13 per cent for NBFCs.

For airlines, there will be no cap, he said, adding that Air India and IndiGo will be eligible for more than ₹1,000 crore.

Also read p3, p10



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QUICKLY.

Manappuram Finance
post ₹405 crore PAT in Q4

Kochi:Manappuram Finance registered 299.2 per cent year-on-year growth in its consolidated profit after tax at ₹405 crore in Q4 FY26. The assets under management grew 22.4 per cent to ₹63,798 crore. Gold loan AUM reached ₹50,953 crore. The total AUM for FY26 was ₹63,798 crore compared to ₹43,034 crore in FY25. In Q4, its income from operations grew 10.7 per cent to ₹2,614 crore (₹2,361 crore). Asirvad Microfinance business reported a profit of ₹13 crore.

Shanthi Gears profit dips
37% to ₹16 crore in Q4

Chennai:Shanthi Gears, the Coimbatore-based subsidiary of Tube Investments of India, reported a 37 per cent decline in net profit to ₹16 crore for Q4FY26 as against ₹22 crore in the same period last year. Revenue declined 13 per cent to ₹135 crore (₹153 crore). For FY26, the company reported a 24 per cent decline in profit to ₹77 crore (₹96 crore). Its board has recommended a final dividend of ₹2 per equity share; the total dividend for the fiscal works out to ₹5 per share.

Coforge Q4 profit jumps
multi-fold to ₹612 crore

New Delhi:IT firm Coforge, on Tuesday, reported a multi-fold surge in consolidated net profit to ₹612.3 crore for January-March FY26, driven by a major one-time tax benefit and strong operational growth. The company had posted a net profit (attributable to owners of the company) of ₹261.2 crore in the year-ago period. Revenue from operations grew 30 per cent to ₹4,450.4 crore in Q4 FY26, from ₹3,422.2 crore a year ago. On a quarter-on-quarter basis, profit more than doubled and revenue grew 5.2 per cent during the quarter under review. Reported Q4 PAT reflects the reversal of deferred tax liability due to the Cigniti merger, the company said in a regulatory filing.

Godrej Enterprises eyes aviation
expansion as exports grow 30%

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Godrej Enterprises Group (GEG) registered a 25 per cent growth in its aerospace business in FY26 and expects higher volume as original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) expand their supplier base to meet the order backlogs. The group's aerospace business supplies components and parts to Indian Space Research Organisation and engine OEMs including Pratt & Whitney, Rolls-Royce and Safran. The company's head of aerospace division Maneck Behramkamdin said FY26 has been very positive for the business with 25 per cent growth in revenue and 30 per cent growth in exports.

Marico FY26 profit up, volume growth at 7-year high

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Marico reported its FY26 results, delivering its strongest volume growth in seven years, with volumes rising 8 per cent in FY26, even as net profit rose a slower 9 per cent to ₹1,813 crore in FY26 from ₹1,658 crore in FY25. Revenue grew faster at 26 per cent to ₹13,611 crore (₹10,831 crore), highlighting margin pressure despite robust demand. Net profit growth trailed a sharp rise in input costs, with the cost of materials consumed climbing to ₹6,197 crore (₹4,572 crore), reflecting the impact of copra inflation. For the March quarter (Q4FY26), revenue rose 22 per cent year on year to

M&M profit surges 42% in Q4, beats
estimates on strong SUV, EV demand

ALL-ROUND SHOW. Aided by margin expansion across businesses including Mahindra Finance, Tech Mahindra

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Mahindra & Mahindra, on Tuesday, reported a strong Q4 that beat estimates, with net profit jumping 42 per cent to ₹4,668 crore and revenue rising 29 per cent to ₹54,982 crore, driven by a 21 per cent growth in vehicle volumes, a 36 per cent surge in tractor sales and rising EV traction with penetration at 9.6 per cent.

The performance was supported by margin expansion across businesses, with Mahindra Finance's AUM at ₹1.34 lakh crore, alongside AI-led initiatives targeting ₹4,100 crore in revenue impact and supply chain measures across a ₹1-lakh crore procurement base to manage global risks. Analysts had pegged Q4 standalone revenue at around ₹38,000 crore and profit in the ₹3,350-3,600 crore range; actual standalone revenue of ₹39,601

crore and profit of ₹3,737 crore came in higher. The 53 per cent jump in standalone profit marked the sharpest upside surprise. For FY26, revenue rose 25 per cent to ₹1,98,639 crore and net profit grew 35 per cent to ₹17,099 crore, with return on equity at 20.1 per cent. Cash balances crossed ₹41,000 crore, supporting future investments.

AUTO BUSINESS

The automotive business remained the primary growth driver, with Q4 volumes rising 21 per cent to 3,06,508 units, including 1,84,000 utility vehicles, while full-year volumes grew 19 per cent. Standalone auto PBIT rose 28 per cent to ₹2,955 crore, with margins at 9.5 per cent, or 10.9 per cent excluding EV-related dilution, reflecting strong operating leverage and mix.

Mahindra retained its No. 1 SUV position (25.3 per cent revenue share) and leadership in LCVs under 3.5

At a glance

Metric	Q4 FY26	y-o-y (%)	FY26	y-o-y (%)
Revenue (₹ crore)	54,982	29	1,98,639	25
Net profit (₹ crore)	4,668	42	17,099	35
Auto volumes (units)	3,06,508	21	11.18 lakh	19
Tractor volumes (units)	1,19,811	36	5.26 lakh	24

tonnes, while emerging as the fifth-largest exporter, just 37 units short of fourth.

The company is scaling capacity to 60,000 SUVs per month by H1 FY27, with EV capacity at 8,000 units, alongside a new greenfield plant planned to support long-term growth.

It has also mapped risks across its supply chain, mitigating them through localisation, multi-sourcing and inventory buffers.

“Our market gains across SUVs and tractors have been driven by strong execution, and importantly, by delivering consistent margin performance even as we scale up volumes,” said Rajesh Jejurikar, Executive Director

and CEO (Auto & Farm Sectors). The farm equipment business saw strong traction, with tractor volumes rising 36 per cent to 1,19,811 units in Q4. Full-year volumes crossed 5.26 lakh units, with market share at 43.6 per cent.

Margins remained robust at 19.4 per cent in Q4 and 19.9 per cent for FY26, while farm machinery revenue grew 32 per cent, signalling expansion beyond tractors.

NEW PROFIT ENGINES

Mahindra's EV business turned PBIT-positive in Q4, with penetration reaching 9.6 per cent of its SUV portfolio. The services segment saw profit rise 64 per cent,

For FY26,
revenue rose
25 per cent and
net profit grew
35 per cent

while Tech Mahindra margins expanded to 12.6 per cent. The group's “Growth Gems” businesses reported 50 per cent profit growth. Mahindra is also scaling AI-led initiatives across auto and financial services, while reducing costs, improving time-to-market and supporting margin expansion.

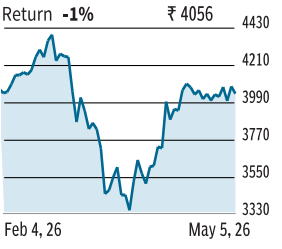
BIZ OUTLOOK

Mahindra has guided for mid-to-high teen SUV growth and mid-single digit tractor growth in FY27. “We have built a diversified growth model with multiple profit drivers, which gives us resilience and confidence as we navigate an uncertain environment,” said Dr Anish Shah, Group CEO and MD.

L&T Q4 revenue up 11%
on steady execution

Our Bureau
Mumbai

L&T



Larsen & Toubro reported an 11 per cent on-year rise in consolidated revenue for the March quarter at ₹82,762 crore, though net profit declined 3 per cent to ₹5,326 crore, largely due to an exceptional gain recorded in the year-ago period. Recurring profit after tax grew 5 per cent to ₹5,289 crore, reflecting steady execution across businesses despite a high base and exceptional impacts in the previous year.

“Revenue growth reflects steady execution, though some projects saw deferred progress due to external factors—we believe these are revenues deferred and not denied,” said President, Whole-Time Director and CFO, RShankar Raman.

Total expenses for the quarter rose around 12 per cent on year to ₹76,000 crore, the fastest annual growth in costs in the last three quarters.

For FY26, the engineering and construction major posted a 12 per cent increase in revenue to ₹2.86 lakh crore, while recurring PAT rose 18 per cent to ₹17,238 crore, underscoring strong operational performance. “Recurring profit growth of 18 per cent underscores the strength of our core operations,” said Raman, adding, “Margins in certain segments were impacted by legacy projects, but this effect will recede as these jobs are closed out.”

The board recommended a final dividend of ₹38 per equity share.

Operationally, the company closed the year with record order-inflows of ₹4.36 lakh crore, up 22 per cent on year, driven by strong traction across infrastructure, energy and hydrocarbon segments. International orders continued to dominate, accounting for 58 per cent of annual inflows. In the March quarter alone, order-inflows stood at ₹89,772 crore, with overseas orders contributing a higher 67 per cent.

The consolidated order-book reached an all-time high of ₹7.4 lakh crore as of March-end 2026, marking a 28 per cent increase over the

previous year and providing strong revenue visibility. International orders constituted 52 per cent of the backlog.

FY27 OUTLOOK

In an analyst call, the management forecast revenue growth at 10-12 per cent in FY27, with margins stable at 8.3 per cent. Order-inflows are seen rising 10-12 per cent with a prospective project pipeline in the range of ₹17-18 lakh crore. Of the total pipeline, infrastructure projects worth ₹9 lakh crore are seen as prospects.

“Given our strike rate, we expect another year of satisfactory growth in order-inflows,” said Raman. “Despite global uncertainties, the opportunity landscape remains encouraging.”

SEGMENT-WISE BIZ

In Q4, the infrastructure projects business reported 15 per cent growth in annual order-inflows, supported by large wins in renewables, transmission and heavy civil infrastructure. The energy projects segment was a standout performer, with order-inflows surging 56 per cent on strong demand in hydrocarbon and carbon-lite solutions.

The company highlighted execution of marquee projects such as the Navi Mumbai International Airport Phase-1, Oman Botanic Garden and major hydrocarbon developments in West Asia. In hi-tech manufacturing, L&T delivered seven steam generators ahead of schedule and expanded strategic partnerships. In its technology and services vertical, it continued to scale digital capabilities, including commissioning new data centre capacity and advancing semiconductor and engineering intelligence initiatives.



Promoter Karan Adani

the right contractor... there was no team initially... and a lot of projects were started without full engineering being done,” he told investors, adding that the company will use the next six months to complete engineering and reset project execution discipline.

Adani stressed that the company is not abandoning growth plans. “We are not moving away from the targets, but from the timeline... it makes sense to step back and course-correct,” he said. “The breakdowns in acquired assets, especially in Penna and Sanghi, have been a problem area.” Adani said, adding that the focus is now on improving plant reliability and stabilisation.

COURSE CORRECTION

Adani said the reset is driven

mand-heavy regions. He added that the structure of acquired assets is also being reshaped.

“Sanghi is predominantly a clinker plus cement asset. In the next year, you will see it moving towards clinker, with capacities coming up in coastal Gujarat region. Dahej is a classic example where Sanghi will supply clinker and the grinding units will supply cement,” he said.

HIGHER COSTS

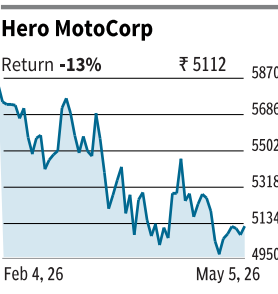
Vinod Bahety, CEO of Ambuja Cement, said the company faced higher-than-expected costs, with March alone seeing a ₹25 per bag spike. He said the FY26 cost of production stood at around ₹4,400 per tonne, against an internal target of ₹4,000 per tonne, though it improved to about ₹4,100

per tonne in March. Integration of acquired assets remained uneven, with Sanghi operating at 56 per cent utilisation and Penna at 46 per cent, while legacy assets were performing better at 75-80 per cent utilisation, and Orient Cement at full capacity. He said the turnaround had taken longer due to higher maintenance capex and deferred upkeep requirements.

Bahety added that some efficiency capex projects were delayed by three-six months, while breakdowns at Penna had added to maintenance costs. Despite the reset, Ambuja continues expansion. However, future expansion will be more selective and cost-driven. Key projects include a new limestone block in Assam and a clinker line at Mundra.

Hero MotoCorp records highest-ever PAT for both Q4 and FY26

Our Bureau
New Delhi



The country's largest two-wheeler manufacturer, Hero MotoCorp said it has posted highest-ever revenue and profits for both the fourth quarter (Q4) ended March 31, 2026, and for the full financial year 2025-26 (FY26).

The company reported a consolidated net profit of ₹1,460 crore in the Q4 FY26, up 26 per cent year on year compared with ₹1,161.33 crore recorded in the corresponding period of the previous fiscal.

Consolidated revenue from operations also rose 30.17 per cent to ₹12,978.28 crore (₹9,969.81 crore), the company said in a regulatory filing.

The company said it sold 17.14 lakh units of motorcycles and scooters in Q4

FY26 — a growth of 24 per cent over the corresponding quarter in the previous fiscal.

RE-APPOINTMENT

Meanwhile, its board has re-appointed Pawan Munjal as the Whole-time Director, designated as the Executive Chairman for a term of another five years, effective October 1, 2026, subject to the approval of the members of the company at the ensuing 43rd Annual General Meeting (AGM) to be held on August

The company
said it sold 17.14
lakh units of
motorcycles and
scooters in Q4
FY26 – a growth
of 24 per cent over
the corresponding
quarter in the
previous fiscal

5, 2026. Suman Kant Munjal, a Director retiring by rotation and being eligible, has also offered himself for re-appointment, subject to the approval of members of the company at the ensuing AGM.

FY26 RESULTS

On an annual basis, Hero MotoCorp reported a growth of 31.13 per cent in its con-

solidated net profit to ₹5,741.73 crore in FY26 compared with ₹4,378.48 crore in FY25.

Similarly, consolidated revenue from operations grew around 16 per cent to ₹47,411.24 crore (₹40,923.42 crore) during the year.

The company sold 64.69 lakh units of motorcycles and scooters in FY26 — a growth of 10 per cent over the previous year, the company said.

DEFINING CHAPTER

“FY26 marks a defining chapter for Hero MotoCorp. Our record performance reflects not only our sustained leadership as the world's largest manufacturer of motorcycles and scooters for 25 consecutive years, but also our commitment to defining the future of mobility,” Harshavaradhan Chitale, Chief Executive Officer, Hero Mo-

toCorp, said.

This growth was broad-based, driven by a strong premium and electric vehicle product portfolio and momentum across both, domestic and global markets, he said.

“As we look ahead, we are encouraged by the supportive government policies, positive consumer loyalty and sentiment, and the accelerating shift towards electrification and premiumisation. These factors position us well for FY27, as we continue to lead the industry's transition towards sustainable and innovative mobility solutions,” Chitale added.

The board also declared a final dividend of ₹75 per equity share.

Including the interim dividend of ₹110 per share, the total dividend for FY26 amounts to ₹185 per equity share, the company added.

Haleon India maintains double-digit growth
momentum, open to inorganic growth opportunities

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



Haleon has been witnessing strong double-digit growth momentum in the India market.

The company, known for its product portfolio that includes Sensodyne, Eno, Crocin and Centrum, has set a goal to reach one billion additional consumers by 2030 globally. It believes growth markets such as India will play a key role in achieving this goal.

In the Q1 earnings call, Haleon's global management said, “India continues to be our star. In India, we grew double-digit with excellent in-market execution... Sensodyne grew at five times the

The company has
set a goal to
reach one billion
additional
consumers by 2030

rate of the category with significant market share gains. Overall, our growth was balanced across price and volume mix.”

Kedar Lele, CEO - India, and President - India sub-continent, Haleon, said that India had been strengthen-

ing market share and aims to further accelerate this growth momentum.

“We will be strongly focused on growing product penetration and expanding distribution reach,” he said.

NEW CONSUMERS

Haleon noted that the launch of Sensodyne at ₹20 had widened the brand's reach with nearly 70 per cent of units being purchased by new consumers.

“In the past 18 months, we have doubled our distribution reach in India. Nearly a quarter of our sales now come from rural regions. We want to strongly grow the household penetration of our brands,” Lele stated.

Asked if the company is looking at inorganic growth

opportunities in India, he said, “We are mapping out possible opportunities. It will be one of our priorities. On one hand, we want to grow our core business; on the other hand, we also want to bring in brands that can add that additional heft to our portfolio.”

The company is also looking to expand into adjacent categories.

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QUICKLY.

‘W Asia crisis to moderate India’s growth by 0.6- 6%’

Samarkand: The ongoing West Asia crisis is going to shade off India’s GDP growth by 0.6 per cent to 6.3 per cent and also stoke inflation in the current financial year, as per the latest update, ADB Chief Economist Albert Park said on Tuesday. ADB in April projected India’s GDP growth to remain “robust” at 6.9 per cent in FY27 and rise to 7.3 per cent in the next fiscal, driven by strong domestic demand. **PTI**

High oil prices put credit strain on fuel retailers

New Delhi: India’s oil marketing companies could see mounting credit pressure if crude prices stay elevated, with delayed fuel price pass-through threatening earnings and cash flow, Fitch Ratings said. Sustained high oil prices would erode EBITDA if domestic pump prices fail to keep pace with rising input costs, while large inventory holdings and refining volumes would increase working capital needs. **PTI**

Cabinet approves two more semicon units worth ₹3,900 crore

CENTRE’S MISSION. India’s first commercial mini/micro-LED display facility based on GaN tech, packaging unit

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Cabinet on Tuesday approved two more semiconductor manufacturing units, with a cumulative investment of ₹3,936 crore, which are expected to generate employment for 2,230 skilled professionals.

BOOST TO SECTOR
The approved semiconductor projects — Crystal Matrix Ltd and Suchi Semicon — under the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) reaching 12, at an outlay of around ₹1.64 lakh crore, from the earlier target of ₹1.60 lakh crore. These would complement the growing world-class chip design capabilities coming up in the country which are propelled by design infrastructure support provided by government to 315 academic institutions and 104 start-ups, Vaishnaw said, adding that momentum is building up further in the semiconductor ecosystem in India with the 10 approved projects already in various stages of execution. Two projects have already started commercial shipments from India and two more are expected to start

With these two approvals, semiconductor ecosystem in the country would get a significant boost with the total number of approved projects under India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) reaching 12, at an outlay of around ₹1.64 lakh crore, from the earlier target of ₹1.60 lakh crore.

These would complement the growing world-class chip design capabilities coming up in the country which are propelled by design infrastructure support provided by government to 315 academic institutions and 104 start-ups, Vaishnaw said, adding that momentum is building up further in the semiconductor ecosystem in India with the 10 approved projects already in various stages of execution.

Two projects have already started commercial shipments from India and two more are expected to start



‘CHIP’PING IN. Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw speaks during a Cabinet briefing, in New Delhi on Tuesday **NAVEEN SHARMA**

commercial shipments soon, he added.

OUTPUT APPLICATION

“Crystal Matrix Limited (CML) will establish an integrated facility for compound semiconductor fabrication and ATMP in Dholera, Gujarat for manufacturing mini/micro-LED display modules. The integrated facility will also provide GaN foundry services, including epitaxy on 6-

inch wafers. The annual proposed production capacity for mini/micro-LED Display Panels is 72,000 sq meters, and for Mini-Micro-LED GaN epitaxy wafers is 24,000 sets of RGB (red, green, blue) wafers,” Vaishnaw explained.

The proposed products will have applications in large displays for TVs and signages/commercial displays, medium-sized displays for tablets, smart-

phones and in-car displays, and micro-displays for extended reality (XR) glasses and smart watches.

Similarly, Suchi Semicon (SSPL) will be setting up an outsourced semiconductor assembly and test (OSAT) facility in Surat, Gujarat, for manufacturing discrete semiconductors. The proposed production capacity of the Suchi Semicon unit is 1,033.20 million chips per annum.

The target applications include power electronics, analog ICs and industrial systems, serving automotive, industrial automation and electronics sectors.

Commenting on the approval, Ashok Mehta, Founder and Chairman at SSPL, said, “This facility will serve domestic and global demand across power electronics, analog ICs and industrial systems.”

Govt revises SOPs on FDI proposals, aims for approval in 12 weeks

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government has issued an updated standard operating procedure (SOP) to streamline the processing of foreign direct investment (FDI) proposals, aiming to make the process paperless and fixing a 12-week timeline for final approvals.

Per the SOP issued by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) on Monday, a FDI proposal must be disseminated by DPIIT to the Ministries/Departments concerned, RBI, the Home Ministry (MHA) and the Foreign Affairs Ministry (MEA) in two days of receiving it. A 12-day window is to follow for scrutiny of the proposal and documents and seeking additional information.

A two-week time limit is then allowed for submission of clarification by DPIIT, while a six-week time period is provided for submission of comments by MHA, MEA and any other consulted ministry/department/RBI/regulator/stakeholder. Finally, the competent authority gets 4 weeks for grant of approval, taking the total time for approval to 12 weeks. “Time-limits shall exclude time taken by applicants in removing deficiencies in the proposals or in supplying additional information,” per the notification.

EASE OF DOING BIZ

The DPIIT will act as the nodal body, seeking inputs from the RBI, the MHA for security clearance, and the MEA, according to an analysis by research body GTRI.

“The SOP will improve ease of doing business by

making FDI approvals faster, transparent, and fully digital, with clear timelines,” it said.

In case of proposals involving total foreign equity inflow of more than the established limits, the authority shall place the same for consideration of the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) within the timeline prescribed. Investments in sensitive sectors like defence, telecom and civil aviation will mandate security clearance, while large proposals will be escalated to the CCEA, the GTRI paper noted.

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Cabinet nod for ₹10/quintal hike in sugarcane price for 2026-27 season from Oct

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Cabinet on Tuesday raised the minimum amount that mills are legally bound to pay growers by ₹10 per quintal, the lowest in three years. After this revision, sugar mills will buy sugarcane at the new Fair and Remunerative Price (FRP) of ₹365 per quintal when they open the factories for the 2026-27 season from October.

“The FRP will be ₹365/quintal for a basic recovery rate of 10.25 per cent,” Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told reporters after the meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA). The approved FRP is 2.81 per cent higher than the current rate of ₹355 per quintal for 2025-26 season.

PRODUCTION COST

While the production cost of sugarcane for 2026-27 was pegged at ₹182 per quintal, the FRP fixed is 100.5 per cent higher than the production cost (A2+FL formula), the government said. The decision is expected to benefit nearly one crore sugarcane farmers, support labourers engaged in sugarcane cultivation and ensure the continuation of operation of sugar factories, Vaishnaw said.

The FRP has been fixed on the basis of recommenda-

tions of the Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices (CACP) and after consultation with state governments and other stakeholders. In the 2025-26 season, out of dues ₹1,12,740 crore, about ₹99,961 crore, or 88.6 per cent, has been paid to farmers, he informed.

While the sugar industry welcomed the decision, farmers said the hike is inadequate.

The Indian Sugar and Bio-energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) said, “It is estimated that this will result in an additional income of over ₹15,000-20,000 crore, taking total cane payments to around ₹1.3 lakh crore in the upcoming season.”

Stressing on its long-pending demand to raise the minimum selling price (MSP) of sugar, ISMA said that while the FRP increase rightly supports farmers, it also raises the cost of raw material for mills.

On the other hand, Dharmendra Malik, spokesperson of the Bharatiya Kisan Union, said a mere increase of ₹10 per quintal is a formality and this is unjust.

He stated that the costs associated with farming — including diesel, fertilizers, labour wages, irrigation and transportation — are constantly on the rise; in such a scenario, this meagre increase proves to be negligible when weighed against the actual cost of production.

New governments often bring fresh vision for industrial policy, says CII chief Rajiv Memani

bl.interview

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

Large infrastructure projects stalled in States with new governments, notably West Bengal, may finally be unlocked, according to CII President Rajiv Memani. He noted that while the West Asia crisis had squeezed MSMEs through rising energy costs and transit bottlenecks, strong economic tailwinds are currently preventing industry panic.

Edited excerpts:

How is Indian industry coping with the effects of the ongoing uncertainty in West Asia?

The Indian industry has faced a series of geopolitical challenges over the last 12-15 months, from Operation Sindoor to US tariffs. The government’s response has been to double down on reforms and proactively engage in free trade agreements with countries where we have complementary strengths.

While we entered the West crisis with strong momentum — GDP growth hit 7.5 per cent, corporate balance sheets are robust, and the investment cycle has picked up — the impact is now being felt through higher input and energy costs.

However, there is no panic. Demand remains steady, and in B2B sectors, pricing transmissions are already happening.

We are seeing industry take tactical steps: managing inventories more conservatively, building working capital buffers, and addressing



In States like West Bengal, where large infrastructure projects have been stuck, this is an opportunity for a “reset” to unlock those projects

RAJIV MEMANI
President,
Confederation of Indian Industry



supply chain risks. Even if the conflict settles soon, it will likely take three to four months for logistics and energy capacities to stabilise.

You mentioned B2B pricing transmissions, but not B2C. Where is that being absorbed?

B2C hasn’t seen the same immediate shift because of existing contracts and inventory pipelines. In B2B, transmission is faster.

If a cosmetic company’s packaging costs rise by 20 per cent, it might only impact their total cost by 1-2 per cent, so they may wait to see if the situation stabilises before passing it to the consumer. If this continues, however, we will eventually see a “price creep”, at which point we must watch for the impact on demand.

Will the recent election results impact industrial momentum?

New governments often bring a fresh vision for industrial policy. In States like West Bengal, where large infrastructure projects have been stuck, this is an opportunity for a “reset” to unlock those projects. It also allows for better Centre-State co-ordination to push for the factor reforms needed to

catalyse investment.

What specific support is the industry seeking from the government right now?

The government has already provided substantive relief by absorbing petrol and diesel price differentials and offering customs and packaging credit relief.

CII is currently making targeted representations, particularly for MSME exporters. Many are facing high demurrage and transportation charges for shipments stuck. Broadly, we believe government funds are best utilised in long-term projects that build India’s resilience in energy and manufacturing rather than broad overall subsidies.

India’s overall goods exports, and particularly to West Asia, have slowed down. Is this a major concern?

I expect exports to pick up once things stabilise. Two factors give us a competitive advantage: new FTAs coming into effect and the currency. Even if the rupee stabilises, it will be 6-7 per cent cheaper than a few months ago.

Globally, there is a strong desire to de-risk supply

chains and partner with stable countries like India. We just need to ensure our manufacturing capacity is ready to meet that demand.

On the import side, not just oil, but non-oil imports, too, have been rising significantly. How do we address this?

That is the real challenge. We have identified about 80 manufactured goods where we see high future demand. We need a specific roadmap for these — identifying required technology, capable companies, and whether they need PLI incentives or temporary protection to establish a local base.

The PLI scheme is a flagship for manufacturing, but results have been disappointing in some sectors. How can it be improved?

We are finalising a report for the government on this. While many schemes have worked well, some saw low uptake due to unrealistic targets or applicants lacking the financial wherewithal to set up full-scale plants.

Our recommendation is to make targets more realistic and, in some cases, move the timelines. PLI remains essential as we pivot toward manufacturing items we currently import, or those with high future demand.

With the US reciprocal tariffs now revoked, are trade prospects looking stronger?

While it takes time to rebuild after a loss of momentum, trade between India and the US will grow significantly. People are also waiting to see what happens with the final trade deliberation. But momentum is picking up.

Tamil Nadu industry curious but not too worried about TVK

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As the C Joseph Vijay-led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) looks to form a government in Tamil Nadu, the State’s industrial ecosystem is curious about the new party’s priorities, but not too worried about a shake up in the well-oiled system.

Industrialists *businessline* spoke to said that a reading of the TVK manifesto suggests that jobs for youth and industrial development remain a priority and hence they are optimistic of policy continuity.

RESERVATIONS

However, officials noted that some industrialists have been trying to understand more about the fairly inexperienced Cabinet and the party’s stance on the new Parandur airport, among other things.



KEEPING OPTIONS OPEN. Companies are trying to understand TVK’s stance on the Parandur airport project, which it resolved to oppose at its first meeting in Vikravandi in 2024 **PTI**

“Bureaucrats play a key role in Tamil Nadu, so a change of government has been fairly smooth in the past. With bodies like Guidance Tamil Nadu, it should be business as usual for us,” a manufacturing industry executive said.

“Their [TVK’s] manifesto indicates jobs for youth and development so now we have to see if they have any limitations in acting up the prom-

ises,” the person added.

An executive said they are used to regime changes in Tamil Nadu, and several key industrial policies are often continued by the new government.

“The difference is that we do not know much about the party and the elected MLAs, who are mostly first timers. But we do see some senior people from other parties [that] part of the core

group,” the person said.

Bureaucrats noted that the TVK’s stance on Parandur has been part of conversations with companies since the results, and added that there is curiosity around its stance on the new airport project and other infrastructure projects.

TVK ON PARANDUR

TVK, at its first political meeting in Vikravandi in 2024, had passed a resolution opposing the Parandur airport project.

Vijay had then said that he was not against development but only against the location of Parandur. Vijay had also met the farmers who were protesting against the project.

Garment exporters in the textile town of Tiruppur have a lot of expectations from the TVK government, especially in developing infrastructure.

They believe there will

now be better coordination between the State and the Centre, unlike the previous regime. “The results are a reflection of a well functioning democracy, but with the new party also having similar set of welfare measures and freebies in their manifesto as the other parties, how they maintain the State’s finances is the key question,” another industry executive noted.

As per an Emkay Global analysis released on Tuesday, TVK’s heavy populist promises, if translated to actual spending, will be 2.2 per cent of GDP of extra spending for the State.

The party, as per its manifesto, goes a step beyond the incumbent DMK’s \$1-trillion economy vision by 2030, by pushing the goal to a \$1.5-trillion economy by 2036. It has also promised support for MSMEs and quick business licences for investors.

With inputs from T E Raja Simhan

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Gold rush

ETF-driven rise in gold demand needs watching

Bullion, after energy, is the biggest contributor to India’s import bill. Bullion imports have traditionally declined when gold prices increased. Buyers cut back on grammage to meet their budgets. However, data from the World Gold Council (WGC) suggests that this long-held pattern is being disrupted. In January-March 2026, gold prices surged 81 per cent year-on-year, and yet domestic buyers actually increased their gold purchases by 10 per cent in volume terms and 88 per cent in the value terms (\$25 billion against \$13 billion).



Since India mines very little gold, this new trend in gold demand (its rising alongside price increase) can escalate the country’s import bill, skew the trade balance and trigger foreign exchange outflows. Unlike energy or electronics imports, which power economic activity, household savings invested in gold are stockpiled and locked out of the financial system. WGC data provides some insights into this change in behaviour. Historically, the bulk of India’s gold purchases has been from jewellery buyers looking to meet wedding commitments, or to use as collateral during distress. Lately though, investors have overtaken jewellery buyers as the main drivers of demand. Until 2024, over 70 per cent of gold demand, in volume terms, originated from jewellery buyers, with 30 per cent coming from bar and coin buyers. In 2025, demand from ETFs (exchange traded funds), bar/coin buyers picked up to 40 per cent of the total. In Q1 2026, purchases by investors in bars, coins and ETFs (exchange traded funds) at 54 per cent actually overtook jewellery buying as the main source of bullion demand. Jewellery buyers singed by the higher prices, cut back their volumes by 19 per cent, but bar/coin and ETF buyers upped their purchases by 34 per cent and 197 per cent respectively. Clearly, asset investors and consumers are acting in contrary ways. When prices spike, investors buy more. If investment demand continues to rise, India could face a secular surge in gold imports, irrespective of prices, widening the trade gap.

There are no easy policy fixes here. As households ramp up equity investments, they do need gold as a hedge against market volatility. Gold is also necessary insurance against geopolitical risks, a depreciating Rupee and debt returns that no longer match inflation. Rather than curb gold imports — which only pushes the activity underground — enabling remonetisation of the 30,000 tonne gold stockpile held by households presents a neat solution. Gold Monetisation Schemes which have failed in the past due to inadequate assaying infrastructure, need to be revived.

The Gem and Jewellery Council recently mooted a monetisation scheme where consumers deposit their physical gold with banks against electronic receipts, freeing up gold for re-use by jewellers. Remonetisation of gold and its re-use can be incentivised by exempting them from capital gains tax. In that case, demand from ETFs and jewellers can to an extent be met domestically, without recourse to imports.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Trump, Merz and Europe’s security

As Donald Trump’s second term has become overshadowed by plunging poll ratings and an illegal, ill-advised war in the Middle East, European governments have regularly been singled out to bear the brunt of the US president’s growing frustration. Sir Keir Starmer’s refusal to militarily back the attack on Iran led to unfavourable comparisons to both Winston Churchill and King Charles. “Unfriendly” Spain has been threatened with a trade embargo for similar reasons. Italy’s prime minister, Giorgia Meloni, previously seen as a key political ally, has also been on the receiving end. Currently it is Germany’s chancellor, Friedrich Merz, who finds himself in Washington’s crosshairs. In the wake of Mr Merz’s accurate observation that the US has no convincing strategy on Iran, the Pentagon has announced the future withdrawal of 5,000 US troops from bases in Germany.LONDON, MAY 4

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

EUROPE

Iran’s Regime Ends the Cease-Fire

The cease-fire in the Persian Gulf has been broken, and the culprit is the regime in Iran. President Trump now faces a decision about how he plans to reopen the Strait of Hormuz: Give Iran’s regime what it wants in negotiations or use the U.S. military to get ships through. On Sunday the President announced Project Freedom to guide commercial ships out of the Strait. Framed as a humanitarian mission to help ships and starving crews locked up in the Strait against their will, this was also a tactical move to break the Iranian blockade and restore energy flows. On Monday U.S. Central Command advised vessels to transit Hormuz on a route near Oman, away from Iran, explaining that it had “established an enhanced security area.” MAY 4, NEW YORK



PRATIM RANJAN BOSE

The BJP has wrested a two-thirds majority in the West Bengal election. For a party with overwhelming presence in the rest of the country, this is not just another win. It’s a homecoming. BJP’s earlier avatar, the Jan Sangh, was founded by legendary educationist Dr Syama Prasad Mookerjee from Kolkata. His untimely death in 1953 and the rise of the Communists weakened the space for BJP. The 2026 win will contribute significantly to strengthening the party’s ideological position.

Typical of the State’s political tradition, BJP’s rise is largely attributed to negative voting against the Trinamool Congress. Bengali Hindus, however, overwhelmingly voted for change. The outcome will strengthen the nation’s security apparatus.

West Bengal is not merely a border State but also maintains connectivity to 8 per cent of India’s landmass in the North-East, accounting for nearly half of the India-China border. A tectonic shift in the political landscape will, therefore, have definite geopolitical significance.

STRATEGIC STATE

The strategic importance of the State had gone up dramatically in the last few years with the rising interests of the US-led West in the Bay of Bengal region and tensions in Bangladesh and Myanmar. India-China rivalry remains a strategic constant.

Mamata Banerjee’s politics of confrontation and tepid interest in growth and infrastructure development was a serious impediment to India’s strategic planning. West Bengal missed the infra-building rush of the country over the last decade. Land was not provided even for border fencing.

The growing muscle of Islamists with connections across the border was an imminent concern. West Bengal witnessed a dozen or more riots in the Mamata era. The police force became politicised and misused, impacting law and order.

Given West Bengal’s history of political violence, coupled with the sustained decline in its economic fortunes over the last half a century, the State became a drag on the national economy. BJP has to revive the State’s fortunes and the job will not be easy.

Decades of Left rule (barring a few years of the Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee government) and TMC, destroyed the economy.

The Left rose to power through destruction of industry and so did



ANI

Daunting task for BJP in West Bengal

ECONOMIC REVIVAL. The BJP has to revive the State’s moribund economy and overhaul the bureaucracy. But it faces a serious funds crunch

Mamata. The results were visible in this poll season when high voter turnout in Bengal triggered a house-help crisis in the rest of the nation.

From third in terms of relative per capita income, Bengal now stands 24th. The decline is visible in a 200-300 per cent difference in agri-wages between West Bengal and Kerala, Tamil Nadu or Gujarat. The gap is wider if compared to North Bengal.

No wonder that Bengalis are crowding out the low-skill job markets from Kashmir to Kanyakumari. The comparison with neighbouring Bihar is revealing. Bihar suffers from high population growth. Bengal, on the other hand, reports India’s lowest total fertility rate (TFR) — lower than China. Population has been shrinking in cities, starting with Kolkata, where TFR is lower than Japan.

At least two generations of small families have triggered aspirations

Given West Bengal’s history of political violence, coupled with the sustained decline in its economic fortunes over the last half a century, the State became a drag on the national economy. The BJP’s task will not be easy

which remained unfulfilled. Jobs are low-paying and offer limited prospects for upward mobility. Politics has patronised dole-oriented, sub-optimal living.

The decimation of Bengal has been all-encompassing. Bihar not only sends out its poor, it is also churning out white-collar professionals in great numbers. Bengal’s bureaucracy and police administration are run by Biharis. Kolkata, however, lost much of its national eminence in areas like law and finance.

FARM DISTRESS

The rural economy is struggling from the ill-effects of land reforms. The small land parcels have become uneconomic. Strict land ceiling and share-cropper rule limit prospects of land consolidation.

The poor give land to the rich on an annual lease. The rich do everything to keep it under their control, but in the absence of ownership they do not make major capital expenditure. Crop diversification and value creation prospects suffer. Bihar does not face such constraints.

The Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee government of CPI (M) tried to reverse the trend by allowing entry of corporates in agri-marketing. His party blocked it. Mamata Banerjee’s politics thrived on the status quo. Less said about her industrial policy the better.

In a bizarre decision in 2025, West

Bengal retrospectively scrapped all industrial incentive schemes offered to businesses over the last three decades. The trigger lies in a lack of resources.

Lack of industries and low income have limited the scope of central tax share. The own-tax collection (approximately 45 per cent) is disproportionately dependent on liquor sales for growth. Own tax revenue buoyancy is low (below 1).

With its promises to double the doles offered by Mamata and implement the Seventh Pay Commission for State government employees and pensioners within 45 days of assuming power, the BJP government will be in a financial crunch from day one.

The saffron party promised to build industrial hubs on land available in the steel city of Durgapur, the port city of Haldia and Singur. This is surely doable but not easy. Any positive impact will take at least a decade to reflect in the overall economic health of the State.

The biggest problem lies in the availability of resources. The problem starts from the bureaucracy, which lacks quality officers, thanks to political interference. BJP has to undertake a thorough but careful overhaul of the system. A roughshod approach may end up creating more problems.

The challenge is huge. People have high expectations from the BJP. Can the party fulfil them?

The writer is an independent journalist

Fundamentals are under some stress

War effects are working their way through trade, economy and financial channels. A structured response is called for

Saumitra Bhaduri
Shubham Anand

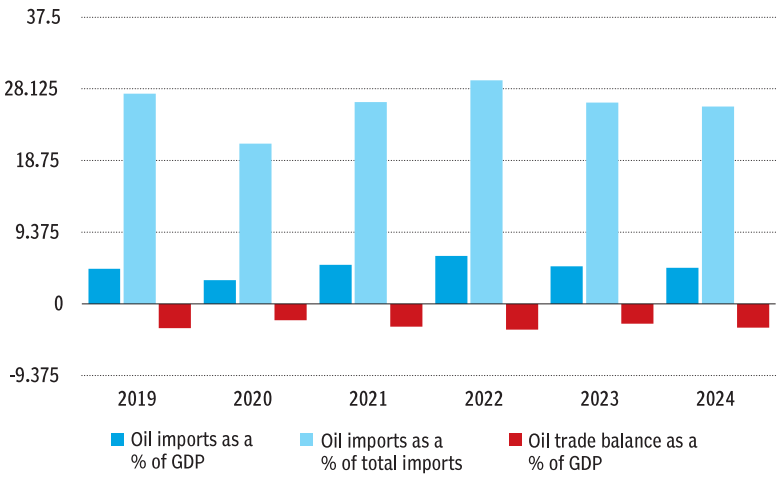
The ongoing pause in hostilities in West Asia has brought immediate relief to the people in the region, but the aftershocks to global energy infrastructure and supply chains persist. The war has disrupted the flow of crude oil and fertilizers creating bottlenecks in logistics and trade. Brent crude remains elevated, and India’s economic outlook is clouded by persistent volatility.

Oil makes up 26-27 per cent of India’s imports, and the oil trade deficit has averaged close to 3 per cent of GDP in recent years (*see figure*). In FY26, India’s current account deficit was about 0.8 per cent of GDP, cushioned by services exports and remittances. But in a supply shock, that cushion shrinks fast because oil demand is relatively price-inelastic in the short run. Therefore, any price spike quickly inflates the import bill.

Next, the rupee, which had been stable for two years has come under pressure. By March 2026, it fell past the 95 mark against the dollar, nearly 10 per cent depreciation over the fiscal year. This was driven by higher oil prices and persistent capital outflows as global investors reassessed risk. In March alone, foreign portfolio outflows topped ₹1.3 lakh crore. While a weaker rupee can help exporters, it also raises the cost of essential imports and adds to inflation.

Despite these pressures, India’s foreign exchange reserves remain

India’s oil share over years



Source: RBI

strong, covering more than 10 months of imports. Short-term debt relative to reserves is also low, around 20 per cent. These buffers provide protection, but their resilience depends on how long global volatility persists and how deep the shocks go. For instance, remittances have provided a strong buffer, but these are at risk as nearly 38 per cent come from the Gulf.

RBI’S RESPONSE

Against this backdrop, the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has chosen to keep policy rates unchanged.

The RBI has acted with targeted measures such as limiting banks’ foreign

currency positions, easing capital rules, and improving access to working capital for small businesses. Its move to limit net open positions of banks in onshore markets helped the rupee recover a bit. While these actions have provided short-term relief, relying heavily on foreign exchange intervention and engineered stability is not a viable long-term strategy.

The stress on the Indian economy is coming through several channels. First is supply disruption. Energy-intensive sectors are directly affected, but the impact quickly cascades to other sectors. The non-availability of fertilizers and other chemicals may affect the output of

agricultural and industrial products, compounding the inflationary impact. Second, logistics costs are rising, as storage and transport are highly energy intensive. Increased logistics costs cascade through the economy, raising the prices of all final products.

Third, Indian exports are taking a hit from both demand and supply sides. The war has affected not only direct trade, but has also caused a slowdown in other major markets. With West Asia accounting for over 16 per cent of India’s exports in 2023-24, any sustained disruption will hit export earnings.

Fourth, fiscal slippage against the budgeted 4.3 per cent of GDP remains a risk, owing to lower excise duty and corporate tax collections, reduced dividend payouts by oil marketing companies (OMCs), and a higher subsidy burden.

Policymakers must remain vigilant. The outcome of the conflict, US tariff investigations, and the monsoon’s performance will all shape the next steps of monetary policy. Until there is more clarity, the RBI’s cautious approach is justified.

Resilience will depend on maintaining a strong services surplus and remittance inflows, while expanding manufacturing so the non-oil tradable base grows. Attracting stable, long-term capital and encouraging local currency financing will be crucial. Structurally, energy security must be addressed.

Bhaduri is Professor and Anand is Ph.D scholar at Madras School of Economics (MSE), Chennai

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Learning from the enemy

This refers to the Editorial “Power shift” (May 5). Despite a series of defeats by Opposition parties including the ones in West Bengal and Assam now, they continue to blame the BJP for real and imaginary derelictions of Constitutional responsibility and nothing else. BJP’s committed cadre and a leadership which is ready to invest in time and a ceaseless energy to guide and perform ensured its victory.

BJP insisted on Hindutva in Assam and campaigned for the “poriborton” of a “corrupt” government in Bengal, but the Opposition kept its anti-BJP rhetoric unchanged.
YG Chouksey
Pune

Apropos, ‘Power shift’, (May 5). India’s latest Assembly round delivered a split but emphatic verdict — sweeping rejection of incumbency in key States, alongside

continuity in Assam and Puducherry. Voters proved impatient, exacting, and ready to disrupt the status quo when governance falters. In West Bengal, the BJP’s surge marked a decisive collapse of Mamata Banerjee’s TMC. Fatigue, corruption, nepotism, and creeping thuggishness, combined with the limits of welfare-led governance, triggered a backlash that upended 15 years of dominance. Tamil Nadu saw a structural rupture as Vijay’s TVK broke the Dravidian

duopoly, sidelining DMK and AIADMK. Younger voters, untethered to old legacies, backed an untested force promising sharper governance. Kerala reaffirmed its cycle, with anti-incumbency lifting the UDF over the LDF.
N Sadhasiva Reddy
Bengaluru

Building resilience

Apropos of the article ‘An agenda for risk mitigation’ (May 5). The author rightly highlights the risks

from volatile foreign portfolio flows and the persistent current account deficit. While diversifying financing sources is essential, we also need steadier progress on the ground. Encouraging household financial savings through better products, pushing manufacturing and exports beyond a few sectors, and maintaining fiscal discipline would help reduce dependence on hot money.
M Barathi
Bengaluru



Implications of Manus

Slow erosion of rule of law in tech geopolitics

GBS Bindra

An attempt by Meta Platforms to acquire Manus, an artificial intelligence start-up, and its subsequent blocking by Chinese authorities, marks more than a routine regulatory intervention. It signals a deeper shift in how states are exercising power over global technology flows, not merely to regulate markets, but to shape them in alignment with strategic and political priorities.

Taken in isolation, China's move is consistent with its long-standing emphasis on digital sovereignty. When viewed alongside recent US actions against TikTok, however, a more concerning pattern begins to emerge: the gradual side-lining of rule-based processes in favour of discretionary state power.

TIGHT CONTROL

For years, China has maintained a tightly controlled technology ecosystem, justified on grounds of national security, data governance, and political stability. The reported Manus decision fits within this broader framework. What makes the current moment distinct, however, is not China's behaviour alone, but the convergence of approaches across geopolitical rivals that once claimed fundamentally different philosophies of governance.

The US, historically a champion of open markets and a rules-based order, offered an instructive example in its posture towards TikTok, owned by ByteDance. The effort to compel divestiture of TikTok's US operations, under the threat of a ban, was framed as a national security imperative. While such concerns may be valid, the process extended beyond established mechanisms such as the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States (CFIUS), combining executive pressure and legislative intervention in ways that raised questions about transparency and procedural consistency. When legal frameworks appear to be stretched or supplemented in this manner, the predictability they are meant to provide weakens.

It is within this evolving context that China's actions must be understood. When one major power normalises interventionist behaviour under broad and sometimes opaque justifications, it lowers the threshold for others to follow. The result is the emergence of a global environment in which legal principles risk becoming



TECH FIRMS. Operate in fragmented regulatory environment

secondary to strategic imperatives. The implications are far-reaching. At its core, the rule of law provides predictability, fairness, and accountability. It assures investors that decisions will be governed by transparent criteria rather than shifting political considerations. It enables firms to plan cross-border investments with confidence that regulatory processes will remain consistent. When state action begins to appear selective or contingent, that assurance weakens.

The effects are already visible. Global technology firms increasingly operate in fragmented regulatory environments, where compliance involves not only adherence to formal rules but also anticipation of political sensitivities. Capital flows become more cautious, and innovation ecosystems risk becoming siloed. Smaller firms, lacking the capacity to navigate such uncertainty, are disproportionately affected.

This is not to suggest that economic decision-making can be insulated from geopolitical considerations. It rarely has been. The more relevant question is whether strategic interests are pursued through mechanisms that offer transparency, consistency, and recourse, or through ad hoc exercises of power that leave affected parties with limited avenues of challenge.

Institutional frameworks do exist. CFIUS, despite its limitations, provides a structured review process.

For India, the erosion of predictable regulatory norms presents a complex challenge. Balancing openness with strategic caution becomes more difficult in an environment where major powers themselves appear to be redefining the boundaries of acceptable intervention. The Manus episode may fade quickly from public attention. The broader trend it reflects will not.

The writer is Distinguished Fellow at the Avinym Foundation and former Managing Director of CGI India

Can the WTO get back on track?

UNCERTAINTY AHEAD. The Yaounde Ministerial Conference has mired the WTO in a deeper deadlock than ever



ABHIJIT DAS

With the meeting of World Trade Organization's General Council scheduled to be held on May 6-7, WTO members have an opportunity to pick up the pieces after the failure of the 14th Ministerial Conference (MC-14) held in Yaounde recently. While on the issue of Investment Facilitation Agreement (IFA) a pathway for breaking the deadlock might be in sight, on some other issues the developments at MC-14 may have made the task of putting the WTO back on track more difficult. These developments are discussed below.

At MC-14 India continued its resolute opposition to the inclusion of IFA as an Annex 4 plurilateral agreement at the WTO. India also signalled the possibility of taking this issue forward by undertaking multilateral negotiations on guardrails for plurilateral agreements. At MC-14 some other countries also adopted a similar approach on this issue. This holds the promise of bringing clarity and certainty on IFA and systemic issues related to plurilateral agreements.

Let us turn to issues on which developments at MC-14 may have deepened the divide among the WTO membership. First, at MC-14 it became evident that the US was interested in an outcome on just one issue — moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions. Unlike the past ministerial meetings where the members agreed to a two-year extension of this moratorium, at Yaounde the US insisted on a longer period of the moratorium. Almost all countries, including India, showed little appetite to resist the US demand and quickly acquiesced to a four-year moratorium. At the end, on account of the stiff opposition of Brazil and Turkiye to this unreasonable demand of the US, no decision could be taken. If the US had



TRADE AGENDA. The forthcoming meeting of the WTO General Council is likely to provide pointers on the trade body's future

confined its ambitions to what had been agreed to on this moratorium at some of the earlier ministerial conferences, a deadlock could have been avoided at Yaounde.

Second, at MC-14 the US strongly opposed the extension of the moratorium on another issue of particular interest to many developing countries: non-violation complaints related to disputes under the agreement on intellectual property rights (TRIPS Agreement). In past ministerial conferences, WTO members had agreed to two-year extension of this moratorium, which mirrored the period of extension of the moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions. This provided an assurance to WTO members, especially the developing countries, that they would not be sued for resorting to various flexibilities under the TRIPS

Perhaps the most controversial issue is the declaration made by a group of 66 WTO members to implement the Agreement on Electronic Commerce through interim arrangements

Agreement. With the US aggressively seeking at least a four-year period of moratorium on customs duties on electronic transmissions but firmly opposing the moratorium on non-violation complaints under the TRIPS Agreement, the stage is set for another negotiating logjam.

ELECTRONIC COMMERCE

Third, and perhaps the most controversial, issue is the declaration made by a group of 66 WTO members to implement the Agreement on Electronic Commerce (AEC) through interim arrangements, with the ultimate objective of subsequently adding it as an Annex 4 plurilateral agreement at the WTO. Controversially, the AEC stipulates that even when it is implemented through the interim arrangements and is not yet part of the WTO, it will be serviced by the WTO secretariat with the Director-General of the WTO (DG) administering certain aspects of the agreement. This is highly problematic for many reasons.

First, WTO rules do not provide for the DG and the secretariat to administer even limited aspects of agreements that are outside the WTO. What is envisaged under the interim arrangements of the AEC amounts to the DG unilaterally arrogating to herself role and responsibilities going beyond the WTO

rules. Second, this development represents a surreptitious attempt by certain WTO members to curtail the role of the entire membership but expand the powers of the DG through the backdoor. Third, this would divert resources away from activities mandated by WTO rules and instead direct them towards initiatives with questionable legal status. Finally, this would take forward the attempts by some developed countries to delegitimise the WTO and push forward their agenda of WTO reform, which would further bend the organisation in line with their interests.

In conclusion, developments at the Yaounde Ministerial Conference have mired the WTO in a deeper deadlock than before. It remains to be seen whether developed countries limit their vaulting ambitions and seek to get this inter-governmental organisation back on track, or they manufacture another crisis for pushing their agenda of remoulding the WTO to further serve their interests at the cost of most developing countries. The forthcoming meeting of the WTO General Council is likely to provide pointers about the future of this organisation.

The writer is an international trade expert and author of the book 'Strategies in GATT and WTO Negotiations'. Views are personal

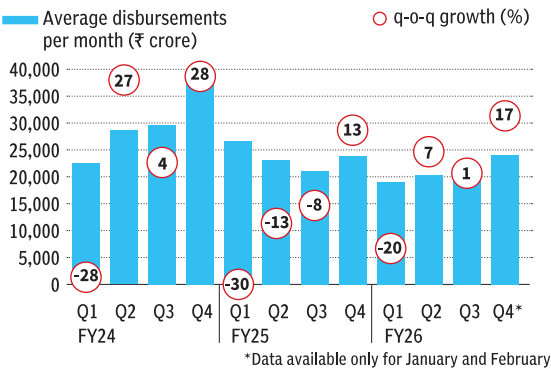
STATISTALK.

Compiled Nishanth Gopalakrishnan | Graphic Visveswaran V

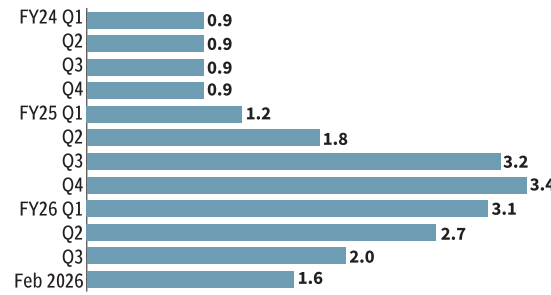
Microfinance sector finds its feet

The crisis in the microfinance sector was the most talked about in banking circles in FY25. With players pushing for growth despite borrowers being overleveraged, bad loans spiralled out of control. In response, the industry adopted stringent underwriting standards, which led to a decline in disbursements. Its portfolio shrank to ₹3.2 lakh crore from the FY24 peak of ₹4.4 lakh crore, led by repayments and write-offs. However, these measures have paid off and a recovery is underway, as shown in the charts below. Nevertheless, with the ongoing scramble for energy, likely higher fertilizer costs and a below-normal rainfall looming large, sustainability of this recovery remains to be seen.

Disbursements recover...

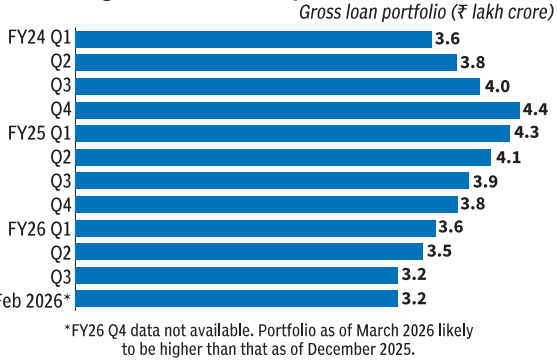


Bad loans contained



Source: CRIF Highmark

...arresting decline in industry loan book



Significant drop in overleveraged borrowers

Active lender associations (share of gross loan portfolio in %)				
	Up to 2	Three	Four	Five and above
FY25 Q1	65.4	15.5	9.5	9.7
FY25 Q2	68.1	15.0	8.7	8.2
FY25 Q3	70.2	14.9	8.2	6.7
FY25 Q4	73.1	14.7	7.3	4.9
FY26 Q1	75.3	14.8	6.2	3.8
FY26 Q2	75.2	16.0	5.7	3.1
FY26 Q3	78.8	15.0	4.3	1.9

Active lender association represents the number of lenders a borrower is indebted to at the same time

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

May 6, 2006

Tatas plan supercomputer venture

The Tata Group is likely to float a new company whose focus will be top-end supercomputers, according to reliable sources in the group. The first initiative of this new venture, in which the Group Chairman, Mr Ratan Tata, is said to have taken personal interest, will be to build a machine based on a parallel supercomputing architecture that Prof Narendra Krishna Karmakar, the well-known Indian computer scientist, has claimed to have developed.

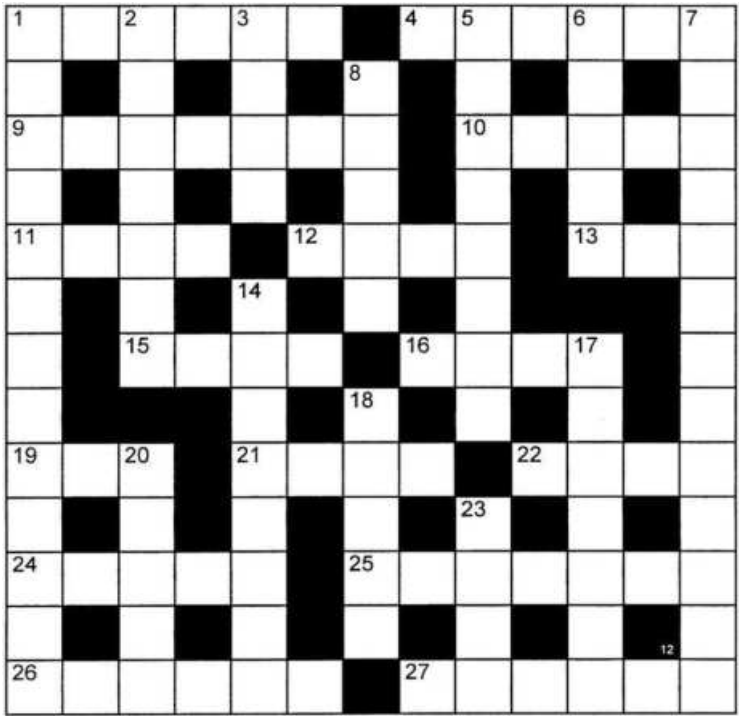
India aiming for Pan-Asian FTA: Manmohan

Having concluded free trade agreements with SAARC, Singapore and Thailand, India is pursuing similar arrangements with other Asian countries, the Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singh, said. Addressing the Board of ADB, he said India is working closely with ASEAN, Japan, China and South Korea.

Hyundai plans 1.2-litre diesel compact car

In a bid to take on car market leader Maruti, the country's second largest carmaker Hyundai Motor plans to introduce a compact car, which could be powered by a 1.2-litre diesel engine. The new car would enjoy the benefit of the excise duty cut announced in this year's Budget.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2673



EASY

ACROSS

- Harbinger of Spring (6)
- Northern sea-duck (6)
- Ancestry (7)
- One resisting authority (5)
- In a frenzy (4)
- Welfare payment order (4)
- First woman (3)
- Turn up with the snout (4)
- Succeed in test (4)
- Reverential wonder (3)
- Return sound (4)
- Parasitic insect (4)
- Forefinger (5)
- Persevere (7)
- Latest, most recent (6)
- Male parent (6)

DOWN

- Joint working (13)
- Sincerity, frankness (7)
- Gemstone (4)
- Two-striper (8)
- Furniture item (5)
- Switchback railway (6-7)
- Satan (5)
- Strikes down as if with halbert (8)
- Void of regard to others (7)
- Give form to (5)
- Settle permanent provision on (5)
- Song in opera (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Clocked a bird for intruding into one's home (6)
- Might provide escort for sea duck (6)
- One's descent from angel that is not straightforward (7)
- Be up in arms with beer about a pound (5)
- Running so wild in the forenoon is all right (4)
- Welfare cheque one had in growth being halved (4)
- Cain's mother would go to and fro (3)
- There's nothing in decay that's at the bottom of it (4)
- Don't answer the question, but get through it (4)
- Reverend one may find in a weekend (3)
- A sound return to be had from the oche (4)
- Caught on the hop it will sound as if it will run away (4)
- Finger that points to the list of contents (5)
- Obstinately continue with press it represents (7)
- The most recent we sent out (6)
- Sire, or an address to priest (6)

DOWN

- Joint effort at making robin coo at all (13)
- Frankness with which cheer-leader can get around (7)
- Stone for ring given to a friend (4)
- Eucharistic cloth for an NCO (8)
- Times list may be on the board (5)
- Or, sell car to re-fashion a ride at the fair (6-7)
- A wicked person starts decrying wickedness (5)
- Fells one in order to please ox (8)
- Flesh is turned to it when not thinking of others (7)
- Form heaps of it (5)
- We'd no alternative but to enrich it with a gift (5)
- A song giving one a change of air (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2672

ACROSS 1. Humanity 7. Phial 8. Million 9. Garment 10. Lock 12. English 14. Shelved 17. Wine 18. Quondam 21. Ailment 22. Eland 23. Deserter

DOWN 1. Humble 2. Molecule 3. Naik 4. Tingle 5. Dice 6. Clutch 7. Paragon 11. Divided 13. Incident 14. Sequel 15. Damage 16. Fetter 19. Oval 20. Flue

QUICKLY.

OnEMI Technology IPO
subscribed 9.5 times



New Delhi: The initial public offer of OnEMI Technology Solutions, which operates digital lending platform Kisst, received 9.5 times subscription on the final day of bidding on Tuesday, mainly supported by strong participation from institutional buyers. The ₹926-crore IPO received bids for 37,76,71,176 shares against 3,97,62,250 shares on offer, as per NSE data. The category for qualified institutional buyers attracted 24.87 times subscription. The quota for non-institutional investors received 6.57 times the subscription, while the portion meant for retail individual investors was subscribed 2.03 times. PTI

Julius Baer names Sumaya as interim India Head

Mumbai: Julius Baer has appointed Kunal Sumaya as ad interim Country Head India, effective from Tuesday. Sumaya will retain his current role as the Global Head of Non-Resident Indian (NRI) Coverage, which he has held since 2022, making it a dual responsibility. The appointment follows the departure of Umang Papneja, who is leaving the Swiss private bank to pursue other opportunities. He will remain with Julius Baer through July 2026 to manage the handover. Sumaya brings 17 years of experience at Julius Baer, having held senior roles including Team Head and Group Head before leading the firm's global NRI business. OUR BUREAU

STT hike impacts equity derivatives trading; BSE attracts fresh interest

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The hike in securities transaction tax (STT) has impacted the equity derivatives trading volume on the NSE even as the BSE mitigated the impact by attracting fresh trading.

The average daily notional turnover (ADT) in the futures and options (F&O) segment on the BSE jumped nearly 20 per cent month-on-month (m-o-m) in April to ₹269 lakh crore. In contrast, the market leader NSE's notional ADT fell about 26 per cent to ₹216 lakh crore.

OPTIONS SEGMENT

In the options segment, NSE's total premium turnover declined 28 per cent m-o-m to ₹12.9 lakh crore, while BSE reported a 6 per cent increase to ₹6.63 lakh crore. Additionally, NSE's average daily premium turnover dropped 35 per cent to ₹61,417 crore, whereas BSE's remained largely flat at ₹33,150 crore. BSE's share in notional

Retail investor, HNI equity holdings fell to 5-year low in March quarter

CONTRASTING STYLE. Stake of MFs and domestic institutions at a record high, that of FIIs dips to 14-year low

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The share of individual investors including high net Worth investors in NSE listed companies declined to a 5-year low of 9.11 per cent at the end of March, down from 9.28 per cent as of last December, as per primeinfobase.com data.

Instead of venturing to invest directly, retail investors and HNIs have taken the MF route to tap the equity markets.

The share of retail investors down from 7.25 per cent to 7.12 per cent, while HNI investors decreased from 2.03 per cent to 1.99 per cent during the quarter.

Individual investors were net sellers to the tune of

₹13,134 crore in the March quarter.

‘GROWING MATURITY’

The share of domestic mutual funds, through which mostly individual investors invest indirectly, reached yet another all-time high of 11.46 per cent in the March quarter against 11.10 per cent in December, the eleventh consecutive quarter of increase.

Pranav Haldea, Managing Director, Prime Database Group, said this trend is an indicative of growing maturity of individual investors, who are increasingly preferring to invest through professional fund manager via mutual funds rather than investing in stocks directly.

In March 2012, the share of mutual funds was 3.21 per

Mood of investors

	Stake hike	Stake decrease
Government (as promoter)	0	2
FIIs	809	932
DIIIs	788	623
MFs	579	465
HNI	1,023	925
Insurance companies	340	369
Private promoters	342	296
LIC	58	80
Retail	836	1,333

Note: December 2025 to March 2026 quarter

Source: primeinfobase.com

cent, while the share of individual investors was 8.51 per cent but in 14 years the trend has changed with individual investors share remaining broadly the same at 9.11 per cent and MFs to jumping to 11.46 per cent.

Meanwhile, FIIs share further declined to a 14-year low of 16.13 per cent from

16.60 per cent in the same period. MFs have continued to narrow the gap with FIIs with the gap in their share declining by a huge 83 basis points in the quarter under review to reach just 4.67 per cent.

The gap has nearly halved in the last two years alone from 9.34 per cent as of

December, 2023. At its peak, the gap was 17.14 per cent in March 2015 with FII share at 20.70 per cent and MF at just 3.56 per cent.

DII SURGE

The share of Domestic Institutional Investors also reached yet another all-time high of 19.24 per cent from 18.72 per cent with a net investment of ₹2.51 lakh crore during the quarter. Apart from MFs, banks and AIFs also played their part with net buy of ₹28,784 crore, ₹1,621 crore and ₹512 crore respectively. The share of private promoters decreased to a 9-year low of 40.58 per cent as of March-end. Over the last 4 years alone, their share has fallen by a huge 464 basis points from 45.22 per cent on December 31, 2021.

SEBI proposes reforms to expand online bond platforms

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has proposed a series of changes to the regulatory framework governing online bond platform providers (OBPPs), including allowing them to offer products regulated by the International Financial Services Centres Authority, thereby enabling access to overseas-listed debt securities through the Gujarat International Finance Tec-City.

Currently, OBPPs can only distribute products regulated by domestic financial regulators such as SEBI, the Reserve Bank of India and others. SEBI said the move



would align OBPPs with stockbrokers, who are permitted to operate in IFSCs.

In a consultation paper released on Tuesday, SEBI sought public comments by May 26 on three key proposals that aim at widening product offerings, streamlining compliance requirements, and improving ease of doing business in the fast-growing retail bond market.

The regulator also proposed permitting OBPPs to

offer tax-saving bonds issued under Section 54EC of the Income Tax Act, as well as similar provisions under the new Income-tax Act.

LISTING AMBIGUITY

These bonds, issued by government-backed entities such as Power Finance Corporation Ltd, Indian Railway Finance Corporation Ltd and REC Ltd, are currently exempt from mandatory listing requirements, creating ambiguity over their eligibility on bond platforms.

SEBI has proposed allowing their distribution with appropriate disclosures on features such as lock-in periods, investment limits and tax benefits, along with disclaimers that investor grievances will lie with the issuer

and not the regulator. SEBI also suggested revising norms for the appointment of compliance officers by OBPPs. At present, such platforms are required to appoint a company secretary as compliance officer.

The regulator now proposes aligning this requirement with stockbroker norms, which do not mandate a specific professional qualification, following representations from industry bodies, including the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India.

SEBI said the proposed changes are based on recommendations of its advisory committee, feedback from stakeholders and an internal review of the OBPP ecosystem.

NSE profit surges 19% to ₹2,871 cr in Q4

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The National Stock Exchange of India reported a 19 per cent quarter-on-quarter (q-o-q) rise in consolidated net profit for the March quarter of FY26 at ₹2,871 crore, supported by robust trading activity in the equity and derivatives segments.

Total income for the quarter increased 22 per cent sequentially to ₹5,360 crore from ₹4,395 crore, while revenue from operations rose 27 per cent to ₹4,968 crore. The growth was primarily driven by transaction charges, which surged 34 per cent q-o-q to ₹4,077 crore on the back of higher volumes.

Market activity remained

Nifty, Sensex slip as tension escalates in West Asia again

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The equity benchmarks closed lower on Tuesday in a volatile session, with the Nifty 50 ending at 24,032.80, down 86.50 points, as a record-low rupee, surging crude oil prices, and renewed West Asia hostilities rattled investor sentiment. The Sensex fell 251.61 points to settle at 77,017.79.

The Indian rupee touched a fresh all-time low of 95.43 against the dollar, with the onshore spot rate settling near 95.34, as Iran intensified attacks on critical energy infrastructure in the UAE.

Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities, said the rupee's record low was “a direct reflection of the unrelenting pressure from West Asia,” adding that India's monthly energy import bill had jumped 70-80 per cent since the conflict began,

while FPI outflows had totalled around \$21 billion.

MIXED TRENDS

Bank Nifty was a notable underperformer, declining 331.45 points to close at 54,547.05.

Auto, FMCG, Pharma, IT, and Metals indices ended in the green, while Realty, Private Banks, PSU Banks, Consumer Durables, and Oil & Gas were the key laggards.

Among individual stocks, Mahindra & Mahindra and UltraTech Cement led the gains on the Nifty, while ICICI Bank, Jio Financial, and Coal India faced the sharpest selling.

Broader markets outperformed the benchmark, with the Nifty Midcap 100 advanced 0.17 per cent and the Nifty Smallcap 100 gained 0.28 per cent. Market breadth was relatively stable, with 240 stocks from the Nifty 500 universe ending the session in positive territory.

However, expenses during the quarter rose 20 per cent to ₹1,486 crore, due to higher provisions. This included ₹223 crore towards corporate social responsibility obligations and ₹84 crore towards settlement applications related to co-location and dark fibre matters.

The exchange has submitted revised settlement terms to SEBI, involving a cumulative pay-out of ₹1,491.21 crore. These applications are currently awaiting regulatory approval. For FY26, NSE reported consolidated total income of ₹18,713 crore and a net profit of ₹10,302 crore.

The board has recommended a final dividend of ₹35 per equity share for FY26, including a special dividend of ₹10 per share.

BROKER'S CALL.

Jefferies

GODREJ PROPERTIES (BUY)

Target: ₹2,475
CMP: ₹1,809.50
Godrej Properties (GPL) reported Q4 net profit (pre-ex) of ₹650 crore, over 70 per cent up year on year, driven by revenue beat which jumped 63 per cent to a record ₹3,460 crore. Reported P&L remains volatile on a q-o-q and the beat was driven by a significant uptick in deliveries with GPL completing 7.4-million-sq-ft projects during the quarter; taking FY26 deliveries to 12.1 million sq ft, above 10 million sq ft guidance. The management guided for 14 per cent rise in pre-sales to ₹39,000 crore for FY27E. The company plans to launch ₹48,000-crore worth of projects in FY27E (vs ₹42,200 crore in FY26), which should help drive pre-sales momentum. While outlook on broader property markets is mid-cycle growth levels; the company said that guidance is subject to geopolitical situation not deteriorating. GPL's reported P&L and FCF generation have improved with PAT over 32 per cent in FY26 and 95 per cent of large land/project expenditure internally funded. The management focus on scaling up deliveries by FY28 to over 20 million sq ft, large pre-sales in base and rising customer collections make us believe that the 20 per cent reported ROE target and net FCF positive are possible by FY28. The stock is trading at 11x PE on reportable PAT/embedded PAT in FY28 P&L/FY26 pre-sales estimates. Our ₹2,475 PT (₹2,420) is set at 12.0x embedded PAT to March 2028 pre-sales. Maintain Buy.

Geojit Investments

NAVIN FLOURINE (BUY)

Target: ₹8,500
CMP: ₹7,009.70
Navin Flourine International has a strong presence across CDMO, Specialty Chemicals and High-Performance Products (HPP) segments. Leveraging deep fluorine chemistry expertise and backward integration, the company serves global pharma, agrochemical, refrigerant and specialty material customers, with exports (about 70 per cent) forming a significant share of revenues. Q4FY26 was strong, with revenue up 34 per cent year on year to ₹938 crore. CDMO revenues grew 61 per cent, Specialty Chemicals 39 per cent, while HPP rose 20 per cent on firm HFC-32 pricing and higher utilisation. FY27 is expected to be a milestone year as major investments transition to revenue. R-32 refrigerant ramp-up in HPP will benefit from strong demand and pricing; multi-purpose plants debottlenecking will boost Specialty Chemicals and CDMO output, and the long-term strategic manufacturing and supply agreement with the Chemours company (in the US) will add long-term, high-margin contracted revenues. This is backed by about 80 per cent capacity utilisation visibility for Specialty Chemicals and a 50-55 molecule CDMO pipeline. As per market consensus, Navin Flourine trades at 43x one-year forward P/E, below its five-year average P/E. The outlook remains positive, supported by strong medium-term revenue visibility, structurally-elevated EBITDA margins (over 30 per cent), rising export mix, a robust CDMO order pipeline, commissioning of the Chemours project, and sustained strength in ref-gas and R-32 capacity ramp-up.

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TODAY'S PICK.

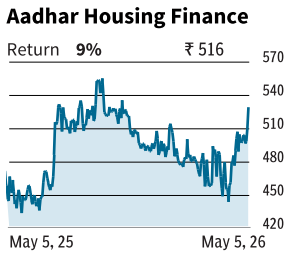
Aadhar Housing Finance (₹516.65): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Aadhar Housing Finance. The 3 per cent rise on Tuesday has taken the share price well above the psychological resistance level of ₹500.

It also indicates that the upmove is gaining momentum. Moving average cross overs on the daily chart also strengthens the bullish case. The region between ₹505 and ₹500 will be a very good support zone. Aadhar Housing Finance share price has potential to target ₹550 in the coming weeks.

Traders can buy Aadhar Housing Finance shares now at ₹517. Accumulate on dips at



₹507. Keep the stop-loss at ₹494. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹521 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹528. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹530 and ₹538 when the share price touches ₹538 and ₹543 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹548.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24129 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23940	23780	24220	24350	Go long only on a break above 24220 with a stop-loss at 24180

₹774 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
770	764	777	782	Go short only below 770. Keep the stop-loss at 772

₹1178 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1160	1150	1200	1220	Can go either way from here. Avoid trading this stock

₹311 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
309	307	313	317	Go short now and at 312. Stop-loss can be kept at 314

₹290 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
288	285	293	296	Go long on dips at 289. Stop-loss can be placed at 287

₹1463 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1455	1445	1490	1520	Go long now and at 1458. Keep the stop-loss at 1445

₹1059 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1045	1030	1070	1085	Wait for a rise. Go short at 1065 with a stop-loss at 1075

₹2430 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2405	2385	2445	2485	Go short on a rise at 2440. Stop-loss can be kept at 2455

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 86.50 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%	
M&M	3210.80	20.32	23.62	2.60	
Infosys	1178.10	7.42	16.21	3.75	
UltraTech Cement	11963.00	5.29	43.05	1.29	
Bajaj Finance	958.60	4.90	30.85	2.33	
Hindalco	1054.70	3.79	14.74	1.39	
Hind Unilever	2327.40	3.50	51.68	1.87	
NestleIndia	1477.80	3.24	81.44	0.96	
Bajaj Finserv	1794.60	3.05	14.60	0.94	
HDFC Life	594.10	1.35	67.03	0.58	
Grochim Ind	2871.50	1.29	20.63	0.98	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	964.40	1.21	22.63	1.23	
NTPC	4373.60	0.95	81.47	1.64	
Apollo Hosp	7772.00	0.77	59.89	0.73	
ITC	311.45	0.74	18.85	2.72	
Reliance Ind	1463.60	0.74	20.68	8.97	
PowerGrid Corp	319.45	0.40	19.14	1.31	
SBI Life	1821.20	0.11	73.95	0.74	
HCL Tech	1200.20	-0.07	19.56	1.15	
Bharat Elec	433.35	-0.16	53.12	1.41	
Cipla	1333.70	-0.16	23.76	0.68	
Kotak Bank	371.35	-0.48	19.15	2.48	
Wipro	199.78	-0.06	15.80	0.52	
Sun Pharma	1038.80	-0.19	54.99	1.75	
Eicher Motors	7301.50	-0.83	37.39	0.91	
TCS	2427.30	-0.89	17.76	2.25	
TataConsumerProduct	1153.50	-0.98	77.57	0.68	
Trent Ltd.	4135.40	-1.12	85.40	0.83	
Int'lBolsv	4238.40	-1.18	51.03	0.87	
Tata Motors PV	340.15	-1.32	46.26	0.85	
WIPAC	398.65	-1.45	15.57	1.71	
Adani Enter	2462.00	-1.48	31.96	0.64	
Tata Steel	211.32	-1.66	28.92	1.58	
Asian Paints	2430.00	-1.78	59.61	1.00	
Max Healthcare	1000.45	-1.80	68.08	0.68	
Bajaj Auto	10046.00	-2.08	31.61	1.01	
Dr Reddy's Lab	1275.10	-2.19	34.87	0.70	
ONGC	289.95	-2.50	8.11	1.02	
Tech Mahindra	1452.20	-2.69	29.61	0.84	
Adani Ports	1725.00	-2.83	31.09	1.15	
JSW Steel	1252.40	-2.90	39.44	1.07	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	248.45	-3.07	101.12	0.74	
Coal India	472.60	-3.64	9.37	0.75	
Maruti Suzuki	13426.00	-4.41	28.76	1.60	
Eternal Ltd.	248.47	-5.39	65.54	1.62	
State Bank	1059.90	-7.69	11.31	3.99	
Axis Bank	1259.70	-9.63	14.75	3.28	
L&T	4054.50	-11.85	29.39	4.32	
Bharti Airtel	1806.10	-14.05	29.70	5.03	
HDFC Bank	772.34	-23.69	15.87	10.72	
ICICI Bank	1251.30	-30.40	15.46	8.12	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 343.45 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	826.90	47.64	117.38	2.27	
Vedanta	303.90	44.37	7.49	2.06	
AdaniGreenenergy	1331.40	38.52	110.57	1.78	
Power Finance	4922.50	35.56	4.52	2.66	
Godrej Consumer	1101.50	32.93	61.87	1.77	
Adani Power	229.96	31.06	34.19	3.80	
Hdfc Amc	2806.30	30.31	42.06	2.29	
HindustanAeronautics	4610.40	27.26	34.66	3.50	
Solar Industries	15845.00	26.54	93.91	1.54	
Tes Motor Cmp	3534.40	25.78	54.99	3.32	
Ltmitndree	4238.80	25.17	25.58	1.99	
TharamandAmamFin	2452.00	25.12	26.58	2.84	
Purv Beverages	511.70	19.12	53.92	2.80	
Britannia Ind	5384.50	13.97	58.16	2.75	
Abb India	732.30	13.55	92.08	1.54	
Pfizer Holdings	10469.00	11.37	13.00	1.81	
Divis Lab	6651.00	11.30	71.22	3.38	
Adani Energy Solutions	1409.60	10.97	70.77	1.95	
Rural Electr	1023.40	10.23	43.75	2.78	
Indian Hotels Co	547.80	10.16	42.60	2.57	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	105.82	8.01	19.74	0.85	
Zydusfinesciences	912.25	6.99	18.26	0.91	
Hindus Zin	611.25	6.98	18.67	1.06	
Torrent Pharma	4275.10	6.88	63.68	1.79	
Tata Power	442.65	5.91	28.24	2.96	
Maazagon Dock	2633.40	4.68	38.55	1.98	
Wipro Cement	2495.00	3.95	49.91	1.33	
Siemens	3846.60	3.12	86.40	1.36	
Bosch	35870.00	0.49	38.38	1.24	
Samvardanomaterialsinternat	120.24	0.37	34.87	1.13	
Union Bank	163.74	-0.16	6.43	2.26	
Jindal Steel	1261.21	-0.21	38.28	1.87	
Pidilint	1384.20	-0.35	60.00	1.69	
Indus Ind Corp	142.14	-1.27	54.56	2.12	
Tata Capital	224.80	-4.21	28.19	0.95	
Canara Bank	134.31	-4.66	6.62	1.81	
United Spirits	1316.50	-5.09	55.63	1.55	
Siemens Energy India	3297.40	-5.82	99.41	1.17	
Gail (India)	163.70	-5.94	12.51	1.76	
Avenuesuper	4358.70	-7.40	95.50	2.56	
Punjab Nat Bank	107.89	-7.69	6.93	1.94	
Wipro Motor India	163.50	-8.85	25.58	1.48	
Bank Of Baroda	29.30	-9.90	6.93	1.95	
Cummins India	5260.00	-11.06	65.04	2.84	
Muthootfin	3446.40	-12.50	15.99	1.48	
Macrotech Developers	997.80	-12.56	26.43	1.02	
Dif	507.30	-17.93	33.39	1.53	
Bpd	298.50	-18.31	5.26	2.42	
Amulja Cements	201.00	-21.00	21.75	1.06	
Amulja Cements	406.55	-37.46	30.51	3.40	
Pts: Impact on index movement					

QUICKLY.
RBI mulls sale of foreign bonds by State lenders



The Reserve Bank of India (RBI), grappling to support the beleaguered rupee, is weighing a plan for state-owned lenders to sell foreign-currency bonds to draw capital inflows, according to sources. The RBI also considered offering foreign-exchange swaps to participating lenders to hedge currency risk, allowing them to offer more attractive yields to investors, they said. **BLOOMBERG**

IIFL Finance revives dollar-bond fundraise

Mumbai: IIFL Finance has revived a dollar-bond fundraise plan and will start meeting investors this week, sources said on Tuesday. The fundraise would help the non-bank lender diversify its sources of funding, as the lender aims to increase the share of external borrowings to 20 per cent from around 13 per cent currently. **REUTERS**

Investors turning to RBI’s retail direct platform for better returns

SOVEREIGN SAFETY. Total number of accounts opened on the system stood at 3,61,402 as on April 27

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Search for better returns on investment is leading the discerning among retail investors towards investment in Government Securities (G-Secs) via the Reserve Bank of India’s retail direct (RBI-RD) facility, going by the number of accounts opened, primary market subscriptions, traded volume and total holdings so far. The total number of accounts opened on the central bank’s retail direct portal jumped about 54 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to 3,61,402 as on April 27, 2026, against 2,35,256 as on April 28, 2025.

TREASURY BILLS
Primary market subscriptions (cumulative) for financial instruments such as treasury bills, floating rate savings bonds, Central G-



BETTER YIELDS. Total traded volume in the aforementioned instruments soared 295 per cent y-o-y to ₹9,167 crore

Secs and State G-Secs rose 35 per cent y-o-y to ₹8,736 crore as on April 27, 2026, (from ₹6,449 crore as on April 28, 2025). Total traded volume in the aforementioned instruments soared 295 per cent y-o-y to ₹9,167 crore from ₹2,322 crore. Total holdings of these instruments rose 50 per cent y-o-y to ₹3,425 crore from ₹2,283 crore. That these instruments are attractive when it comes to fetching better yields can be gauged from the fact that while a 5-10 year term deposit placed with the State Bank of India will earn a depositor 6.05 per cent interest, investment in a 10-year Central G-Sec and a 10-year State G-Sec will fetch a return of 6.48 per cent (semi-annual) and about 7.70 per cent respectively. Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder & Managing Partner, Rockfort Fin-cap LLP, said RBI Retail Dir-

ect is increasingly emerging as a preferred investment avenue for retail investors as it brings together sovereign safety, better yields, zero cost, and a fully digital, transparent framework. “Recent State development loan auctions, particularly for long-tenor securities above 10 years, have been clearing in the 7.70-7.80 per cent semi annual range, offering a meaningful yield pickup over bank fixed deposits, which are largely below 7 per cent,” he added. **PREFERRED CHOICE** “Importantly, these are sovereign-backed, zero-credit-risk instruments serviced directly by the RBI, giving investors the highest level of safety and payment assurance,” he said. Srinivasan emphasised that RBI Retail Direct is enabling retail investors to access institutional-grade fixed income opportunities with higher yields, liquidity and complete transparency — without taking any additional credit risk. This makes it a structurally superior and increasingly preferred alternative to traditional products such as bank FDs and small savings schemes. Further, a RBI Retail Direct mobile application was launched two years ago, offering retail investors a single sign-on facility for seamless navigation between primary market and secondary market modules of the application. Last year, unified payments interface single-block-and-single-debit payment mode (UPI mandate) was introduced to enable investors to pre-authorise transactions and block funds in their accounts for debits to be initiated as per the scheduled timeline for placement of bids in primary auctions.

Rupee headed for more weakness

Gurumurthy K
bl research bureau

The rupee was knocked down badly over the last couple of weeks. The domestic currency fell to a new low of 95.43 against the dollar on Tuesday. It closed the day at 95.29.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

A strong rise in crude oil prices over two weeks is weighing on the rupee. The Brent crude oil price has surged about 18 per cent from around \$96 per barrel to \$113 per barrel now.

MORE UPSIDE
On the charts, the bullish case for oil has strengthened and the broader picture remains bullish for crude oil. For now, \$105-\$116 looks likely to be the trading range for the near term. From a big picture, there is a strong support around \$100. As long as the price stays above \$100, Brent crude oil has the potential for a rise to \$125-\$130 in the coming

weeks. This can continue to keep the rupee under pressure. More room for rise in oil price indicates that the domestic currency can be beaten down more going forward. Oil price has to go below \$100 and sustain lower. Only then it can give some relief for the rupee. That is possible only if the US-Iran war stops. Such a situation seems unlikely at the moment. As such, we may have to look for much higher oil price and more weakness in rupee.

CURRENCY OUTLOOK
The rupee continues to remain under pressure. Immediate resistance is at 95. Above that 94.80 will be the next resistance. Rupee can fall further to 95.90 or even 96.15 in the coming weeks. The level of 94.50 will be a crucial resistance. Rupee has to breach this hurdle to get a breather. Only then, a recovery to 94 and 93.50 will come into the picture. For such a move to happen either oil price has to decline and sustain below \$100 or the central bank should intervene.

Cholamandalam sees 23% AUM growth in FY27

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai



Arul Selvan, President & CFO of Cholamandalam Investment & Finance

Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company Ltd (CIFCL), an NBFC from the Murugappa Group, has guided for a 20-23 per cent growth in assets under management (AUM) for FY27, a growth in line with the 21 per cent growth it achieved in FY26. “Overall, we have done reasonably good performance this quarter and we expect to continue doing so in the coming year. The disbursement in vehicle finance has been good because the auto segment has also started turning around,” Arul Selvan, President and CFO of Cholamandalam Investment and Finance, told *businessline*.

DISBURSEMENTS UP 25%
This comes at a time when the NBFC saw disbursements grow by 25 per cent y-o-y in the quarter ended March 2026 largely led by vehicle finance and other new business areas such as gold loans. However, the guidance has been kept conservative, given that the NBFC is closely monitoring the impact of the West Asia war, which it expects to be multi-pronged. “One [impact] is that it may increase the diesel price

and cost of fuel because large part of our customers are vehicle finance customers, where their primary raw material is diesel,” Selvan said. “But our customers are mostly smaller operators, and they do not have long-term contractual obligations, so we do not expect a large impact,” he added. However, in case of shortage of raw materials and inputs, it could create gaps in production and demand, and then lead to a business hit for transport operators, he said. In this regard, the management has created an overlay of ₹200 crore as a measure against the West Asia war. On the impact of the lower-than-expected monsoon, the company said it is monitoring whether the situation will be concentrated in certain parts of the country or if it will be widespread.

PNB profit grows 14% to ₹5,225 cr in Q4

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Scorecard			
	(January-March quarter)		
	2024-25	2025-26	% change
Net profit (₹ cr)	4,567	5,225	14.4
Operating profit (₹ cr)	6,776	7,500	
Net interest income (₹ cr)	10,757	10,380	-3.5
Gross NPA (%)	3.95	2.95	-
Net NPA (%)	0.4	0.29	-
Return on assets (%)	1.02	1.06	-
Earning @share (₹)	3.97	4.55	

Punjab National Bank (PNB) on Tuesday reported net profit of ₹5,225 crore during the three month period (Q4 of FY26) ending March 31, 2026. It is 14 per cent higher than ₹4,567 crore in the corresponding quarter of FY25. The bank has recommended a dividend of ₹3 per equity share. This is 150 per cent of the face value of ₹2 each for FY26. The record date for this would be June 13. Meanwhile, shares of the bank closed at ₹107.90, down nearly 1 per cent on Tuesday. Provisions for the quarter saw a significant decline to ₹424 crore from ₹1,150 crore during the previous quarter,

and this seems to have contributed to net profit despite a fall in net interest income, which declined 3.5 per cent to ₹10,380 crore compared to ₹10,757 crore during the same quarter last year. PNB’s total global business increased 10.79 per cent from the previous year to ₹29.72 lakh crore. Its total

global deposits were up 9.25 per cent from the previous year to ₹17.1 lakh crore, while its gross advances increased 12.97 per cent to ₹12.61 lakh crore. **DEPOSITS UP** On the domestic front, PNB’s total business increased 10.39 per cent to

₹28.45 lakh crore. Domestic deposits were up 9.14 per cent at ₹16.49 lakh crore, while gross advances jumped 12.17 per cent to ₹11.95 lakh crore. Ashok Chandra, PNB MD and CEO, said the bank achieved all the guidance for FY26, except for current account-saving account and net interest margin. “We gave a guidance of 11-12 per cent for credit growth and 9-10 per cent for deposit growth, while actuals are 12.7 per cent and 9.2 per cent respectively. For FY27, the guidance for advances is 12-13 per cent, while for deposits, it is same as of FY26.” When asked about plans for fundraising during the current fiscal, he answered in the negative as the capital position is strong.

‘Safeguarding the core architecture of inflation targeting a policy choice’

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The decision to preserve the inflation targeting framework’s core architecture is a policy choice of consequence in the backdrop of geopolitical tensions, supply chain disruptions, energy price volatility and an uneven global growth outlook making the macroeconomic environment more complex and less predictable, according to RBI Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta. The Government of India had issued a gazette notification on March 25, renewing the existing inflation target of 4 per cent with 2 per cent tolerance band for five more years, extending the current inflation target (IT) mandate through March 2031. “Renewal of India’s inflation targeting framework through March 2031 has come at a moment of considerable global uncertainty... The review strengthens the framework precisely when it is most needed,” Gupta said in her speech delivered on Tuesday at the National Council of Applied Economic Research in New Delhi. She emphasised that the decision to continue with the existing framework is not to

be construed as inertia towards change; the framework’s durability over the past decade reflects a willingness to learn from experiences. **WHAT FUTURE HOLDS?** “This begs the question of what might a future review look like? One could perhaps consider tweaking the level of inflation and the tolerance band a bit (keeping in view the international experiences, it would point towards a slightly lower inflation and a slightly narrower band),” she said. “But if the global environment remains as challenging as it has been during the past six years, it would warrant both predictability and flexibility inherent in the existing framework,” Gupta said. On an ongoing basis, the RBI too, on its part, could consider some further refinements, particularly with regard to more engagement on its core inflation measures, she added. “More, better, and timely communication has been a work in progress and will continue to remain so,” she said. Gupta underscored that price stability and growth had proved complementary rather than conflicting objectives under the Indian IT framework.

Sundaram Home Finance net profit up 15% at ₹282 cr

Our Bureau
Chennai



D Lakshminarayanan, MD, Sundaram Home Finance

Sundaram Home Finance, the wholly-owned subsidiary of Sundaram Finance, has registered a 15 per cent rise in its net profit for the year ended March 31, 2026, at ₹282 crore as compared to ₹245 crore in the preceding fiscal (FY25). Disbursements for FY26 went up 5 per cent to ₹6,842 crore as against ₹6,517 crore in FY25. Assets under management went up by 14 per cent at ₹19,909 crore (₹17,428 crore) **NEW MILESTONE** The disbursements in the emerging business segment, comprising affordable housing finance and small-ticket loans, crossed a milestone of ₹500 crore in FY26 and ended the year with ₹590 crore (₹229 crore). During the year, the company also crossed the milestone of 100 emerging business branches while adding over 500 employees and close to 5,000 customers. “The emerging business has expanded to Karnataka,

Andhra Pradesh and Telangana on the back of an established presence in Tamil Nadu. The emerging business segment saw a strong growth with disbursements more than doubling in FY26. The contribution of this segment to the overall disbursements is now close to 10 per cent,” D Lakshminarayanan, MD, Sundaram Home Finance, said in a statement. On the outlook for the year, he said in both the prime and the emerging business segment, the company expects significant opportunities available in mid-tier and smaller towns. “Our expansion into new tier-4 and -5 towns will drive our growth in the emerging business segment this year,” he added.

GHCL Limited

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EXTRACT OF AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED MARCH 31, 2026

(₹ in Crores)

Sr. No.	Particulars	STANDALONE			CONSOLIDATED		
		Quarter Ended	Year Ended	Quarter Ended	Quarter Ended	Year Ended	Quarter Ended
		31.03.2026	31.03.2026	31.03.2025	31.03.2026	31.03.2026	31.03.2025
		Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited
1	Total Income	808.44	3,143.93	807.12	804.11	3,137.64	804.81
2	Net Profit before tax	164.19	648.68	211.52	159.86	642.33	209.17
3	Net Profit after tax	119.97	478.81	152.62	115.64	472.46	150.27
4	Total Comprehensive Income (after tax)	116.40	474.28	149.42	111.96	468.10	146.76
5	Paid Up Equity Share Capital (face value of ₹10/- each)	91.93	91.93	95.75	91.93	91.93	95.75
6	Other Equity excluding Revaluation Reserve as per the audited balance sheet		3,459.96			3,459.96	
7	Earnings per Share (face value of ₹10/- each)	(Not Annualised)		(Not Annualised)	(Not Annualised)		(Not Annualised)
	(a) Basic	12.73	50.83	15.96	12.28	50.17	15.72
	(b) Diluted	12.73	50.80	15.95	12.27	50.15	15.70

Note : The Above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual financial results filed with the stock exchange under regulation 33 of the SEBI (listing obligations and disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly / Annual financial results are available on the website of BSE Limited (URL : www.bseindia.com), the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (URL : www.nseindia.com) and on the company's website (URL : www.ghcl.co.in).

Result Link: https://ghcl.co.in/wp-content/uploads/2026/05/Results_Q4FY2026.pdf

ISO 9001 ISO 14001 OHSAS 18001

A Dalmia Brothers Enterprise

Noida
May 05, 2026

For and on behalf of Board of Directors of GHCL Limited

R. S. JALAN
Managing Director
DIN-00121260

RAMAN CHOPRA
CFO & Executive Director (Finance)
DIN-00954190

A CH-CE

QUICKLY.

Gold climbs off more than 1-month low



Gold prices rose on Tuesday after hitting a more than one-month low in the previous session as investors assessed a fragile Middle East truce and the conflict's potential impact on inflation and interest rate expectations. Spot gold was up 1 per cent to \$4,566.79 per ounce at 1245 GMT. US gold futures gained 1 per cent to \$4,577.60. Spot silver firmed 1.1 per cent to \$73.53, platinum gained 2 per cent to \$1,984.55, and palladium rose 2.4 per cent to \$1,515.05. REUTERS

Crude oil slips but war gives floor to drop

London: Global oil prices slipped a day after the US launched an operation aimed at reopening the Strait of Hormuz to shipping, although exchanges of fire between the US and Iran limited the decline. Brent crude futures eased \$2.99 to \$111.45 a barrel at 1322 GMT. US West Texas Intermediate crude fell \$3.7 to \$102.72. "Prices continue to trade in a highly volatile range," said Phillip Nova's senior market analyst Priyanka Sachdeva. REUTERS

Copper snaps 3-week low on bargain hunting



London: Copper prices rebounded after hitting a three-week low as investors took advantage of lower prices, while US prices outperformed on speculation about possible tariffs on the metal. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME rose 0.6 per cent to \$13,075 a tonne by 1415 GMT. In the US, Comex copper futures gained 2.5 per cent to \$5.99 a lb, giving it a slight premium of about \$130 a tonne over LME copper. Aluminium advanced 1.2 per cent to \$3,565, lead rose 1.1 per cent to \$1,970. REUTERS

WGC to launch single platform for responsible mining

PHYGITAL GOLD. The council is exploring ways to link physical and digital gold via shared infrastructure to offer gold-as-a-service

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

The World Gold Council (WGC) is looking to come up with a unified platform on responsible mining standards, consolidating all approaches and standardising them, said WGC Chief Financial Officer Terry Heyman. The standards include how mines should operate, address environmental concerns and take care of human and labour rights, he told *businessline* in an online interview.

"The WGC is looking at opportunities to link physical and digital gold via shared infrastructure to offer gold as a service.

"We do a lot of work around responsible mining. We have what's called the responsible gold mining principles that set out what any largescale miner of gold should do when it comes to mining gold, how they should operate, how they should practice environmental considerations, human rights and labour

rights," he said.

CODES OF PRACTICE
Any mining company anywhere in the world at any stage of development can follow this consolidated mining standard.

The WGC is putting in a lot of effort as it is important to its members, who are the world's largest gold mining companies.

"It's important to the mining industry more broadly to give confidence to everybody that their products have been mined responsibly," said Heyman, adding that there are organisations that support responsible purchasing.

"There are absolutely strong codes of practice in place. It's an area that demands continual scrutiny and continued raising of the bar," he said.

OFFERING A PACKAGE
Linking physical and digital gold will create more opportunities in India, he said, adding that the WGC is looking at sharing infrastructure in this regard.

“We want to make sure that all digital gold products ultimately can be linked back to physical gold sitting in a vault somewhere

TERRY HEYMAN
CFO, World Gold Council



"Companies are looking to create new digital products, and they have got lots of ideas around creating a product, creating the digital interface, connecting with customers, who their target customers are and what those customers are looking for. Where they struggle is linking that back to gold sat in a vault, and they understand that there's the need for this product to be connected physically in a vault somewhere," said Heyman.

It is here that the WGC

can help, by connecting firms with infrastructure providers for vaulting, assurance, know your customer (KYC) norms and responsible sourcing.

"We can bring that all together and essentially offer that as a package that will be a service that can be offered to any product provider that they can then link their token or their collateralisation product or their payment product back into this pool of gold," he said.

This is where the WGC is talking about shared infra-

Cabinet approves ₹5,659 crore for 5-year Cotton Productivity Mission

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Tuesday approved the much-awaited Mission for Cotton Productivity with an estimated expenditure of ₹5,659.22 crore over a five-year period (2026-27 to 2030-31), which is aimed at addressing the sector's bottlenecks, declining growth and quality concerns.

The Cotton Mission was proposed by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in her Budget speech in February 2025, and the government has formulated it after 15 months.

"The Mission envisages accomplishing the production of 498 lakh bales (of 170 kg each) of cotton by enhancing lint productivity from 440 kg/ha to 755 kg/ha by 2031. Approximately 32 lakh farmers will be benefited, leading to self-reliance. Pro-



motion of Kasturi Cotton Bharat for traceability and certification, targeting trash reduction less than 2 per cent and promotion of natural fibres like flax, ramie, sisal, milkweed, bamboo and banana. This is a milestone in making the country self-reliant in cotton sector," the government said in a statement.

In 2025-26, cotton production dipped to 290.91 lakh bales from 297.24 lakh bales in 2024-25 despite the acreage remaining stagnant at 114.8 lakh hectares in the past two years. More assured returns from maize and

paddy, as well as crop risk from pink bollworm (PBW) pest, are driving cotton farmers to cut acreage. In the past six years, cotton area has shrunk by a maximum of 20 lakh hectares among all other crops, data show.

AGRI MINISTRY
Per the Cotton Association of India estimates, in the 2025-26 season (October-September), the production may be 324 lakh bales, consumption 315 lakh bales, import 47 lakh bales and export 15 lakh bales. The trade body pegged the closing stock on March 31 at nearly 292 lakh bales.

The Mission will be implemented by the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare and the Ministry of Textiles, involving 10 institutes of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research, one institute of the Council for Scientific and Industrial Research, and 10 centres of the

All India Coordinated Research Project on Cotton operating in State Agricultural Universities of major cotton-growing States.

5F VISION
businessline had earlier reported about the Mission plan when it was awaiting Cabinet nod, and according to sources, from the overall outlay of ₹5,659.22 crore, the Textile Ministry will spend about ₹1,100 crore, the Department of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare over ₹4,000 crore and the ICAR less than ₹600 crore.

The mission aligns with the 5F vision (farm, fibre, factory, fashion, foreign) of the government, the statement said. The Mission will focus on enhancing cotton productivity through the development of high yielding variety seeds resistant to disease and pests, and scaling up of existing and latest crop production technologies.

SEBI proposes early pay-in for commodity options

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Capital market regulator SEBI plans to introduce early pay-in (EPI) settlement for options contracts in the commodity derivatives segment, extending a facility currently available only for futures.

In a consultation paper issued on Tuesday, it said it had received representations seeking EPI benefits for options as well. The proposal was examined by a working group reviewing the delivery and settlement framework for agricultural commodity derivatives. It recommended extending EPI to options contracts.

The recommendation was subsequently placed before the Commodity Derivatives Advisory Committee at its February meeting, which broadly agreed with it. SEBI has invited public comments on the proposal by May 26.

Buy aluminium futures if they decline to ₹362

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl, research bureau

Aluminium futures (May), after hitting a peak of ₹379.65 per kg on April 27, saw some moderation in price in the following session. It is currently trading at ₹372.

In last week's analysis, we had forecast the price to drop to ₹350-360 before the contract resumes the next leg of uptrend.

COMMODITY CALL.

But the price action during this period shows that it has formed a base at ₹362 on the back of the 21-day moving average. Therefore, the likelihood of a dip to the ₹350-360 price band has now dropped.

That said, we are likely to see a time correction before the next uptick, which could lift aluminium futures above

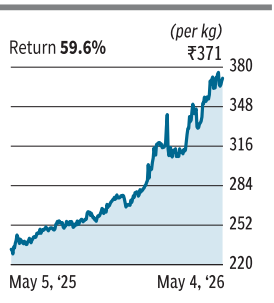
ROLE IN INDIA
In India, gold continues to play an important role as a form of jewellery as well.

The WGC outlook for India is positive on the jewellery and investment side.

Though the council does not provide forecasts on price, it sees individuals continuing to view the case for holding gold as part of a balanced portfolio. The WGC "strongly believes" that there will be increased demand for gold.

Stating that the body of gold miners was supporting trust in the entire gold value chain, Heyman said the organisation is committed to making sure that consumers can trust their gold, and they have confidence that any digital product is underpinned by physical gold.

Stating that the state of digitalisation in India is exciting, the WGC CFO said the country believes in gold and understands the role that the precious metal plays in helping people manage financial security over generations.



the previous high of ₹379.65. Once the contract breaks out of ₹380, it could swing up to ₹400. On the other hand, if the aluminium futures slips below ₹362, it could extend the decline to ₹350. A break below this could turn the outlook bearish, wherein the price could drop to ₹328.

TRADE STRATEGY
Buy aluminium futures (May) when the price drops to ₹362. Place stop-loss at ₹345. When the contract rises to ₹385, alter the stop-loss to ₹370. Book profits at ₹395.

Horticulture FPOs urged to focus on B2C model

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Farmer producer organisations (FPOs), especially in horticulture, have made strong strides in supplying to organised retail and export markets.

Experts say that the next phase of growth lies in shifting focus to consumers — through brand-building, traceability and quality assurance.

"Our horticultural produce has come of age and emerged as a promising export contributor over the last decade. But its potential remains under-realised due to fragmented supply chains, brand invisibility and limited consumer trust," said Rajendra Srivastava, Professor of Marketing Strategy and Innovation at the Indian School of Business.

Addressing a conference on "Building a global farmer-



led brand in horticulture: Strategies for scale, trust, and market leadership", he cited Sahyadri Farms and Amul as examples of how collective strength and professional governance could transform farm-gate economics.

"There is a need to develop 500 collectives like Sahyadri Farms to take agriculture and allied sectors to the next level," said Srivastava, who is also Executive Director of the ISB Centre

Experts say the next growth phase hinges on brand-building, traceability and quality assurance

for Business Innovation (ISB-CBI).

BRANDED EXPORTS
Experts from FPOs, agribusinesses and policy circles discussed ways to transition India from a commodity-based horticulture exporter to a value-added, brand-driven player, leveraging its agricultural diversity and geographical indication (GI) tags. The key challenges flagged included supply chain inefficiencies and inconsistent quality.

Vilas Shinde, CEO of Sahyadri Farms, called for industry status for the horticulture sector to unlock its

processing and export potential.

He said the FPO, with over 50,000 farmer members, plans to consolidate its position over the next two decades with a sharper focus on marketing and brand-building.

SCALE & TRUST
Himanshu Pathak, Director General of the International Crops Research Institute for the Semi-Arid Tropics (ICRISAT), emphasised that scale, trust and market leadership are critical pillars for building strong agricultural brands.

Around 70 delegates, including FPO leaders, agribusinesses, policymakers and academicians, participated in the conference.

A case study titled "Sahyadri Farms - A Report on Farm-led Agri-business Transformation", prepared by ISB-CBI, was released on the occasion.

Procol helps Zuari FarmHub in speeding up its freight procurement cycles

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

Procol, an Agentic AI procurement platform, has announced that it has enabled Zuari FarmHub, part of the Advntez Group, to accelerate its freight procurement cycles by up to 95 per cent while achieving nearly 6 per cent cost savings through AI-led sourcing and real-time price discovery.

A media statement said that Zuari FarmHub partnered with Procol to digitise and centralise its freight sourcing operations.

By leveraging Procol's AI-powered sourcing suite, including smart RFQs, real-time e-auctions, and analytics dashboards, the company streamlined vendor communication, improved participation, and enabled structured, data-driven procurement.

SPEEDY PROCESS

The introduction of real-time e-auctions enhanced price discovery, while custom approval workflows ensured faster and compliant decision-making.

Additionally, centralised spend analytics provided complete visibility across locations, strengthening audit readiness and enabling more strategic sourcing decisions, it said. As a result, procurement cycles that previously took up to 2-3 have now been reduced to within minutes.

Kerala fishers seek study before deep-sea fishing permits are issued

Our Bureau
Kochi

Fishing communities have urged the Prime Minister to constitute a committee to assess fish stocks before issuing high-seas fishing permits to companies and large vessels.

Paul Rajan Mampilly and Joseph Xavier Kalapurackal,

President and General Secretary of the Federation of Fishing Boats and Fishery Industries of Kerala, said the panel should include experts from traditional fishing communities, whose experience spans all weather conditions.

The government is reportedly preparing to issue high-seas permits to companies and large vessels to tap deep-sea resources. The

current permit system is based on pre-2000 studies of fish availability.

Around 3 lakh fishing boats of various sizes are currently operating in the deep seas.

However, if the optimal catch levels are considered, only about 96,000 boats may be required.

This makes it essential to reassess fish stock levels and

sustainable catch capacity before expanding the permits.

UNIFORM FUEL PRICING
The fishers also called for uniform diesel price across marine fuel outlets.

At present, two categories of outlets sell fuel at different rates, creating wide price disparities that lead to overcrowding and delays.

The financial results can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided



For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

M Karunakaran
Whole-time Director & CEO
DIN: 08004643

Date : Coimbatore
Place : 5 May, 2026

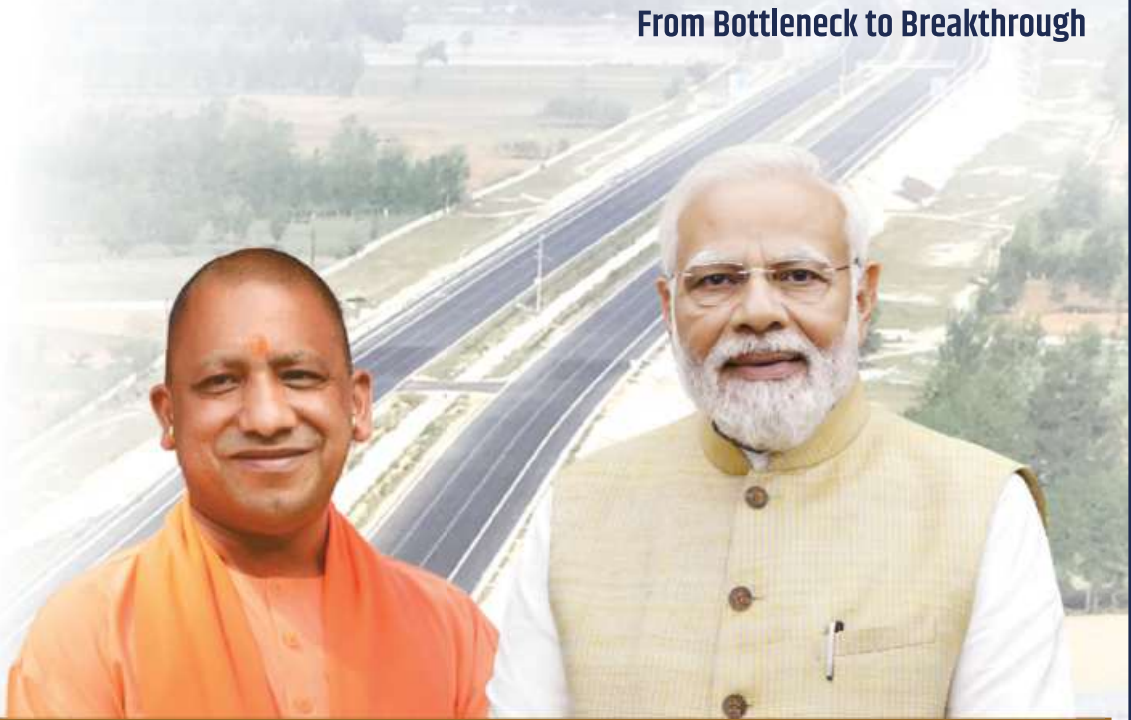
Uttar Pradesh:

India's Fastest-Growing Investment & Employment Hub

Driving Industrial Expansion • Enabling Enterprise • Creating Opportunity

Guided by the principles of Reform, Perform, Transform, Uttar Pradesh has rapidly established itself as one of India's most dynamic investment destinations.

In the past nine years, the state has attracted private investment proposals exceeding ₹50 lakh crore, with the potential to generate over 1.10 crore employment opportunities, reflecting both scale and sustained policy momentum.



From Bottleneck to Breakthrough



₹50+

LAKH CRORE

Private investment proposals



1.10

CRORE

Potential Employment



₹15+

LAKH CRORE

Projects Grounded (Through 4 GBCs)



60

LAKH JOBS

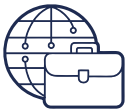
Employment generated



5th GBC

PROPOSED

₹6 Lakh Crore Investment Pipeline



Global Investor Outreach & Strategic Engagements

Uttar Pradesh has sought to deepen its global investment linkages through a series of targeted international engagements:

- Roadshows organised in Singapore and Japan
- Participation from 450-500 global investors and financial institutions
- More than 60 high-level meetings led by the Chief Minister
- Continued strengthening of international partnerships and investor interest

These efforts indicate a calibrated push to position Uttar Pradesh as a credible and competitive investment destination on the global stage.



GLOBAL INVESTOR CONFIDENCE

Uttar Pradesh's proactive global engagement reflects rising international confidence in its economic vision.

World Economic Forum 2026

₹2,94,255 crore MoUs signed at the World Economic Forum 2026

Sectors: AI & Data Centers

- Food processing
- Renewable energy
- Defense manufacturing

A transparent, technology-driven governance framework continues to position Uttar Pradesh as a preferred destination for global capital.

Pharma Conclave 1.0

₹10,000 crore MoUs at Pharma Conclave 1.0 With leading companies. • Biozenta • Shukra • Pharmaceuticals • Walter Bushnell Enterprises Ltd. • Arna Pharma



INDUSTRIAL INFRASTRUCTURE

A robust and future-ready infrastructure backbone is accelerating industrial expansion across the state.

Key developments include: • IIT GNL, Greater Noida • Mega Food Park, Bareilly • TransGanga City, Unnao • Plastic and Garment Parks, Gorakhpur • Flatted factory complexes across multiple regions

The Yamuna Expressway region is emerging as a major industrial hub with projects such as Film City, Toy Park, Apparel Park, Handicraft Park and a Logistics Hub.

Specialized parks, including Pharma Park (Lalitpur-Jhansi), Perfume Park (Kannauj) and Medical Device Park (VEIDA), are strengthening sector-focused growth.



MANUFACTURING GROWTH

Uttar Pradesh's manufacturing sector reflects sustained expansion backed by policy support and infrastructure readiness.

FACTORY UNITS

REGISTERED UNDER FACTORIES ACT, 1948

14,169



MORE THAN DOUBLE IN LESS THAN A DECADE

31,459

February 2026

GVA GROWTH

(AS PER LATEST ANNUAL SURVEY OF INDUSTRIES)

25%

RANKED 1st AMONG ALL MAJOR STATES IN INDIA
MORE THAN DOUBLE THE NATIONAL AVERAGE OF 11.9%

UTTAR PRADESH

NATIONAL AVERAGE

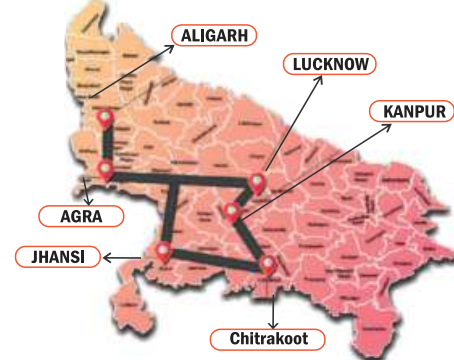
Industrial performance has been equally strong: • 25% growth in Gross Value Added (GVA)
• Ranked 1st among major states • More than double the national average of 11.9%



DEFENCE INDUSTRIAL CORRIDOR

Uttar Pradesh is emerging as a strategic hub for defence manufacturing in India.

- Defence Corridor spanning 6 nodes: Jhansi, Chitrakoot, Lucknow, Aligarh, Agra, Kanpur
- 1,649 hectares land acquired



197 MoUs signed



₹34,844 crore Investment potential



52,658 direct employment opportunities

Land allocation and industrial activity are progressing steadily, with multiple units already operational.



EASE OF DOING BUSINESS

Structural reforms are simplifying business operations across every stage, from approvals to execution.

- 99% minor criminal provisions eliminated
- 39 provisions decriminalized
- 4,675 compliances reduced
- Integration with National Single Window System (NSWS) underway

These reforms are fostering a transparent, efficient, and investor-friendly environment.



TRADE AND PREPAREDNESS

Uttar Pradesh continues to strengthen its export competitiveness and global integration.

Export Preparedness Index (Jan 2026)

Ranked 4th in India

Ranked 1st among landlocked states

Compliance Reduction

Ranked 1st in the country

A streamlined regulatory framework is enabling businesses to scale globally.



SECTORAL DESKS

Sectoral Focus Areas



Textiles & Apparel



Automobile & Electric Mobility



Chemicals



Electronics



Global Capability Centers (GCCs)

Dedicated investor support ensures seamless engagement and faster decision-making.



COUNTRY DESKS (FOR FDI)



Germany



France



UAE



Singapore



Japan



South Korea



Taiwan



United Kingdom

“ From policy to production, Uttar Pradesh delivers speed, scale and certainty, making it a preferred global investment destination. ”

Uttar Pradesh: Powering India's Growth Engine

With progressive policies, world-class infrastructure, and a strong commitment to ease of doing business, Uttar Pradesh is accelerating industrial growth and building a future-ready economy.



QUICKLY.

Apple explores using Intel, Samsung to build chips



Apple Inc has held exploratory discussions about using Intel Corp and Samsung Electronics Co to produce the main processors for its devices in the US, a move that would offer a secondary option beyond long-time partner Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. **BLOOMBERG**

Zee sues Nykaa over alleged misuse of songs

Zee Entertainment has sued fashion-to-beauty retailer Nykaa for allegedly using its copyrighted songs in Instagram reels to promote its products to millions of followers, seeking ₹1.99 crore in damages, previously unreported court documents show. The hearing of the case will be held on May 26. **REUTERS**

Biocon’s Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw picks niece Claire as heir apparent

LEADERSHIP SHIFT. The elevation comes at a pivotal time when Biocon is undergoing organisational changes

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

In an industry where women-led boardrooms remain scarce, Biocon is scripting a rare double, founded by a woman and set to be led by one again, as Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw names niece Claire Mazumdar her heir apparent.

Signalling a phased handover rather than an immediate exit, Shaw said in a post on X that Claire would “transition into my role at the right time,” adding she is “not planning to hang up my boots just yet.”

LEADERSHIP JOURNEY

At 37, Claire represents a new generation of biotech leadership, one that sits at the intersection of deep science, venture investing, and company-building.



Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw (left), founder of Biocon, and Claire Mazumdar, Chief Executive of US-based Bicara Therapeutics



She is currently the founder and chief executive of Bicara Therapeutics, a Boston-based, Biocon-incubated oncology company focused on next-generation bifunctional antibodies for targeted cancer therapies.

Founded in 2020, Bicara has quickly scaled into a global clinical-stage biotech with a growing pipeline and international investor in-

terest. Before launching Bicara, Claire built experience across the biotech value chain, working at Third Rock Ventures, a prominent life sciences venture firm known for backing breakthrough science, and at Rheo Medicines, where she focused on business development and corporate strategy.

Her academic credentials mirror this dual grounding in

science and business: a degree in biological engineering from MIT, followed by an MBA and a PhD in cancer biology from Stanford University.

RESEARCH FIRST

Claire’s rise also reflects a family steeped in academia and research.

Her father, Ravi Mazumdar, is a University Research Chair Professor at the University of Waterloo, while her brother, Eric Mazumdar, is an assistant professor at California Institute of Technology, specialising in artificial intelligence.

Based in Boston, Claire operates at the heart of the global biotech ecosystem, bringing with her a networked, research-first approach that could shape Biocon’s next phase of growth.

Her elevation comes at a

pivotal time for Biocon, which is undergoing leadership and organisational changes, including a sharper focus on advanced biologics and innovation-led growth.

For Shaw, who started Biocon in 1978 as a small enzymes venture in Bengaluru and built it into one of India’s most recognised biopharma companies, the choice of successor appears rooted as much in capability as in continuity.

PHASED TRANSITION

Claire Mazumdar’s appointment, while still part of a phased transition, signals more than a leadership change; it reflects Biocon’s intent to align its future with cutting-edge science, global capital, and next-generation therapeutics.

With additional inputs from intern Vasundhara Prakash

Reappointments of Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh to Tata Education Trust blocked

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Former Tata Trusts trustee Mehli Mistry has opposed the reappointments of Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh to the board of Tata Education and Development Trust (TEDT), sources said.

Another trustee JN Mistry also opposed the reappointment, the sources added. A resolution for the proposed reappointments had been circulated among the trustees, they said.

TEDT is one of the allied trusts of Sir Ratan Tata Trust but does not have any stake in Tata Sons.

GOVERNANCE LAPSES

The objections to the reappointment of Srinivasan and Singh are understood to be related to the governance lapses that Mehli Mistry had alleged in his filings with the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner, said sources with knowledge of the matter.

Earlier *businessline* had reported that Mistry, in his filings with the Charity Commissioner, had alleged that Singh had taken commissions from Tata Sons in violations of the Trust Act.

He had also alleged that Srinivasan had misused his position, as a nominated director on Tata Sons’ board, to get design work done by Jaguar Land Rover’s then COO Gerry McGovern, free of cost for TVS subsidiary Norton Motorcycles. Singh, a former bureaucrat, told *businessline* that he had not yet been informed by the Trusts about the status of his reappointment, which was up for renewal effective May 10.

He added that he had intended to step down on the completion of his tenure and that there was no question of



Venu Srinivasan



Vijay Singh

his contesting the opposition. Both Mistry and Srinivasan did not respond to messages sent to them for clarification.

This development comes just two days before a crucial meeting of the board of Tata Trusts, on May 8 and 12, where the trustees will be deliberating on the future trajectory of Tata Sons, its unlisted status, as well as some rejig on the board of the holding company.

MAJOR DECISION

A major decision that is expected during the meeting is replacement of Srinivasan with Bhaskar Bhat as a nominee director on the board of Tata Sons. This is intended to strengthen Tata’s position and enable him to push through any crucial decisions in his favour. The rift between the trustees, which began soon after the death of Ratan Tata in October 2024, has only widened over time.

AP clears power distribution licence to Google data centre

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad



HIGH-VALUE RETURNS. The State government has been actively promoting data centres as a key growth sector

Andhra Pradesh government has cleared power distribution licence to the upcoming Google data centre in Visakhapatnam in line with a new first of its kind policy.

While there is no official confirmation from the State Government and Google on the Discom licence for its data centre, a source confirmed the development stating that it will be announced in due course.

A couple of weeks ago, the Government, through an or-

itate data centre(s) that are possessing the requisite expertise to obtain a distribution licence for data centre (s) already being developed or proposed to be developed in the State,” an order issued by the Energy Department said.

This makes Andhra Pradesh the first State to give distribution licences to private firms outside the power sector.

SINGLE DEVELOPER

The data centre projects undertaken by a single developer or investor with a minimum connected load of 300 MW or above within the

State are eligible for DDL, as per the order. A single investor may aggregate connected load across multiple data centre locations within the State to meet the threshold.

The power supply should be restricted exclusively to data centre(s) loads within the licensed area.

The DDL shall not supply power to any third-party consumer outside the licence area approved by APERC. In the power procurement, the DDL would have the freedom to procure power from any lawful source, including renewable energy generators through

bilateral PPAs, open access, captive generating plants (including solar, wind, and hybrid with BESS), and power exchanges.

growth sector, The State government has been actively promoting data centres as a key growth sector, in view of their potential to attract high-value investments, generate employment and position the State as a digital infrastructure hub.

Last month, the foundation stone was laid for Google Cloud India AI Hub in Anakapalli district which is being set up with \$15 billion investment.

Reliance Industries plans refinery unit shutdown for annual maintenance

Our Bureau
Mumbai



The shutdown is expected to be some time in June

Reliance Industries will be shutting down one of its refinery units in Gujarat with a capacity to refine 3.3 lakh barrels of crude a day, as part of its annual maintenance exercise, sources said, though no definite date has been specified.

The shutdown is expected to be some time in June, though sources aware of the matter said that it can take place later too.

Some other refining units may also be shut down for maintenance, but sources indicated that this could be a staggered exercise. “Shutdowns for maintenance have to be taken, but whether we do it one month from now, or

three months ... is a decision that is yet to be taken,” said a source. Some units such as the continuous catalytic reformer and paraxylene units have already been shut down for maintenance, the sources said. RIL did not respond to a request for comment.

CRUCIAL TIME

This shutdown is coming at a crucial time when the coun-

try is struggling with scarcity in several crude derivatives including liquified petroleum gas, due to the West Asia crisis.

LPG is a byproduct of crude oil refining and refiners in India, including Reliance, have been directed to step up production of the gas that is vital for both commercial and residential use.

In its earnings call, the

company had said that it had increased LPG supplies to the domestic market almost four-fold.

The government has formed a joint working group comprising the Ministry of Petroleum, Ministry of Department of Chemicals, Petrochemicals and couple of other ministries also such as food and public administration to ensure that end-consumer segments are able to get a regular supply of LPG.

Sources indicated that the shutdown will be undertaken keeping these dynamics in mind and that adequate precautions will be taken so that sufficient stocks of LPG is available and supply disruptions are minimal. “It will be ensured that sufficient products are available,” said a source.

Pixxel bags deal on hyperspectral imaging for NRO

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based space tech start-up Pixxel has secured a contract from the US National Reconnaissance Office (NRO) to provide advanced hyperspectral remote sensing capabilities, in a significant boost to its global ambitions in the defence and intelligence segment.

The award, granted under the NRO’s Commercial Systems Program, will focus on evaluating and integrating commercial hyperspectral data into the agency’s remote sensing architecture.

Pixxel will leverage its on-orbit Firefly satellite constellation to demonstrate how hyperspectral imagery can provide deeper insights into materials, environmental conditions and activities that are not detectable through traditional imaging systems.

‘AI layoffs may create budget room, but won’t deliver returns’

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Among organisations piloting or deploying autonomous business capabilities, approximately 80 per cent report workforce reductions, according to a survey by Gartner.

However, those reductions do not appear to translate into return on investment (ROI).

The survey found that workforce reduction rates were nearly equal among respondents reporting higher ROI from autonomous technologies and those experiencing only modest gains or negative outcomes.

Gartner surveyed 350 global business executives in the third quarter of 2025 to understand the current state of autonomous business at

enterprises. Qualifying organisations reported enterprise-wide annual revenue of at least \$1 billion or equivalent, and they had been piloting or had already deployed at least AI agents, intelligent automation or autonomous technologies.

TRUE AUTONOMY

Using technologies such as AI agents, intelligent automation, RPA, digital twins and tokenised assets, autonomous business will move organisations from simple augmentation and automation to true autonomy, where both machines and people have more autonomy. This does not mean humanless business; rather, it means human-amplified business.

“Many CEOs turn to layoffs to demonstrate quick AI returns; however, this dis-

position is misplaced,” said Helen Poitevin, Distinguished VP Analyst at Gartner. “Workforce reductions may create budget room, but they do not create return. Organisations that improve ROI are not those that eliminate the need for people, but those that amplify them”

NEED FOR PEOPLE

Gartner forecasts AI agent software spending will reach \$206.5 billion in 2026 and \$376.3 billion in 2027. This is up from \$86.4 billion in 2025.

“Long term, autonomous business will create more work for humans, not less. Lasting structural factors such as demographic decline and high-stakes, trust-dependent consumer moments will ensure human talent remains central for governing and scaling autonomous business,” said Poitevin.

Rajasthan Royals bid process ‘lacks level-playing field’

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi



with existing “approved” investors, including Manoj Badale, owning the balance 7 per cent stake.

“We are deeply disappointed not to be part of the Rajasthan Royals ownership group, following a long six-month process, in which we were the lead bid from start to finish,” a joint statement issued by Somani, Rob and Jordan Walton and Michael Hamp said on Tuesday.

The statement said that the group of investors had been “fully funded”, and was prepared to close the trans-

action and did not withdraw the bid.

“We had executed documentation in place and were told that the franchise’s board meeting on Saturday was held to approve our consortium. In the end, this was never the case. We approached this process with the highest standards of honesty, integrity, professionalism and in good faith, but unfortunately, that wasn’t enough,” the statement noted.

“We do not believe the outcome ultimately reflected a level-playing field, and it is difficult to reconcile the strength of our bid and preparedness to close with the final decision. While we respect competitive outcomes, we also believe that processes of this significance should be conducted with transparency, consistency, integrity and in good faith.”

Emcure hits ‘sweet spot’ on weightloss brand Poviztra

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Despite the slew of generically similar versions of semaglutide recently launched in India, Emcure Pharmaceuticals expects its weightloss drug Poviztra (semaglutide injection) to be one of its top brands, Emcure executives said, even as the company crossed a milestone of \$1 billion revenues for the year ended March 31, 2026.

Emcure sells the innovator Novo Nordisk’s Wegovy under a second brand name, and earlier, in April, it had slashed prices on the product by over 50 per cent.

FULL MIGHT

“We’ve proactively taken a very steep price cut, and we really believe that this price is now a sweet spot,” Samit Mehta, Emcure Whole-Time Director, told *businessline*, adding that close to 1,000 medical representatives



PRICE WAR. Emcure sells the innovator Novo Nordisk’s Wegovy under a second brand name. Earlier, in April, it had slashed rates on the product by over 50 per cent

across divisions and specialities are focused on promoting the product.

“We put the full might behind Poviztra. And the early indications, even after genericisation, look positive. Eventually, over the course of this year, we expect this to be one of the top brands for us,” he said.

Satish Mehta, Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director, pointed out that

usually there was a huge differential between the innovator’s product and generics, after the patent expires.

“Here, what has happened because of the proactive approach taken by Novo Nordisk, the difference between generic and innovation is not very significant. So obviously, we have a competitive advantage because of the correct pricing strategy or aggressive pricing strategy

backed up by science, clinical data. And that is paying dividends,” he added.

Semaglutide is the active ingredient in Danish healthcare major Novo Nordisk’s weightloss product Wegovy and diabetes product Ozempic. And with a basic patent on semaglutide expiring late-March in India, among other markets, a number of generic drug-makers launched similar versions at 50-80 per cent of the innovator price.

In this case, the innovator Novo Nordisk and partners Emcure and Abbott had also undertaken price cuts, making the innovator product competitive.

PROFIT SURGE

Emcure executives were speaking after the company announced its financial performance for the fourth quarter and FY26. The company’s revenue from operations stood at ₹9,204 crore, up 16.6 per cent over last

year; and its profit after tax stood at ₹941 crore, up 33.1 per cent.

Emcure’s Q4 revenue from operations stood at ₹2,470 crore, up 16.7 per cent over the same period last year. Its PAT stood at ₹244 crore, up 23.6 per cent over Q4, last year.

Satish Mehta said, “We strategically expanded through in-licensing, Zuventus minority buyout and bolt-on acquisitions in the UK and Canada. Our research and development pipeline in complex injectables and biosimilars remains a key driver of future value.” The company could look at a local acquisition opportunity in strategic therapeutic areas, he added.

As the war continues in West Asia, the company officials said most companies had inventory for about two quarters in the pipeline. But the impact would be felt if it continues unabated, they added.

